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Coordinating the Field

The Case for Ecosystem-Level Technology Roadmapping and Community Working Groups in Active Inference

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Abstract

Active inference is approaching a critical developmental juncture. The theoretical framework has matured substantially over the past decade, and applications are emerging across domains from clinical medicine to autonomous systems. Implementations now exist in more than one language and institutional setting, and domain communities have begun to form. The field has not yet established a coordinated developmental infrastructure of the kind that has distinguished scaling fields from those that plateau.

This paper reviews the historical record of roadmapping and working-group coordination across fifteen cases, and seven cases in which coordination gaps appear to have contributed to developmental limitations. Those histories are directly instructive for design. They show how independent convening, named objects of work, and public outputs have been associated with durable field-level coordination, and how the absence of those features has been associated with fragmentation, expectation-reality gaps, and delayed recovery.

The paper proposes that community working groups, convened by the Active Inference Institute, are a useful and appropriate form for the next stage of that work. Year one forms the groups, agrees on a shared assessment framework, and runs initial assessments. Year two proposes domain roadmapping as the next step, decided group by group. The Field Working Group holds a terminology correspondence matrix, a comparison protocol for existing implementations, and the shared assessment framework. Domain working groups produce literacy materials, an initial self-assessment, and a published go/no-go.

All interested parties are invited to the Charter Development Session at the [Sixth Annual Applied Active Inference Symposium in November 2026](#).

All updated information on the Call for Working Groups, Charter, Operating procedures, and more, are available at https://github.com/ActiveInferenceInstitute/Working_Groups/ . You can also access these documents on the AII website at: <https://activeinference.institute/working-groups/>

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1. INTRODUCTION: THE INFLECTION POINT

Active inference—the computational framework grounded in the Free Energy Principle and its mathematical formalization—has developed from a theoretical account of biological self-organization into a testable and increasingly applied framework.^{1,2} Implementations now span neuroscience, robotics, clinical psychiatry, cognitive science, and decision theory. The body of relevant research has grown substantially over the past decade. Domain-specific communities of practice have begun to form in several application areas. A new generation of researchers is encountering active inference as a viable foundation for applied work.

This convergence has reached an inflection point: the developmental moment at which early theoretical elaboration gives way to the harder work of domain education, application development, implementation and field-wide organization. The decisions made in the forthcoming years about which domains receive focused development effort, which educational programs and tools are built, and which standards emerge under whose authority will shape the field's development for years to come. Those decisions are already being made, by research groups, by companies, and by grant-making bodies, largely in isolation from each other. The question before the active inference community is whether those decisions continue to be made independently or whether the community develops shared infrastructure to make them collectively.

This paper makes the case for the collective path and describes the mechanism—a system of community working groups (WGs) organized and convened by the Active Inference Institute—through which that path can be pursued. It draws on the roadmapping and governance literature, on the development histories of comparable fields, and on the governance models of the bodies that have done this kind of work most effectively. The historical evidence is organized in two tables in Section 3.

The paper proposes a Field Working Group (FWG) plus Domain Working Groups (DWGs), operating under a Field charter and a customizable domain-charter template. We propose that the Field group produces a terminology correspondence matrix, a comparison protocol, and a shared assessment framework. We propose that domain groups produce literacy materials, an initial assessment, and a published go/no-go on the group's continuation. Domain roadmapping is proposed as year-two work after the assessment.³

This paper was drafted by the listed authors and circulated to members of the AII Board of Directors (BoD) and the Scientific Advisory Board (SAB) for comment and was approved by the BoD for publication as an AII position paper. The proposed charter and operating procedures in the appendices are offered to the community as a starting draft for these founding documents, and are open to amendment before or at the November 2026 Symposium. The proposed charter and operating procedures are online at the links on the cover page of this paper and are open to community review, comment, and suggested changes.

¹ Karl J. Friston, "The Free-Energy Principle: A Unified Brain Theory?," *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 11, no. 2 (2010): 127–138.

² Karl Friston, Thomas FitzGerald, Francesco Rigoli, Philipp Schwartenbeck, and Giovanni Pezzulo, "Active Inference: A Process Theory," *Neural Computation* 29, no. 1 (2017): 1–49.

³ Section 2 is orientation. Year-one work is identified in Section 8. The Symposium call, the Field Working Group, the interest gate, and the product-fit participation conditions are design features of the pilot. Any number of domain groups may form if they meet those conditions. Working groups are constituted by their members. AII may withdraw as convener. AII may not dissolve a group.

Section 2 orients the reader to current field conditions. Confirming those observations is a background task. Proposed year-one WG work is identified in Section 8.

2. OBSERVABLE COORDINATION CHALLENGES IN THE ACTIVE INFERENCE ECOSYSTEM

The observations that follow are based on preliminary review of publicly visible field infrastructure—publications, conference records, software repositories, and community platforms—and on the experience of the Active Inference Institute as a convener of the active inference community since 2020. They are a starting orientation for readers. A systematic empirical survey remains to be done and may become later work of the Working Groups. The Working Groups may comment on these observations; any such comment is advisory. Year-one continuation does not rest on confirming them.

Terminological Divergence

Active inference is described using distinct terminological systems across research communities, with limited correspondence established between them. Terms such as "free energy," "generative model," "belief updating," and "epistemic value" carry specific technical meanings that vary across implementations and research traditions. No field-endorsed glossary currently exists to coordinate usage across communities. This is a predictable feature of early-stage field development. It becomes a coordination cost as practitioners from different communities attempt to engage with each other's work, and a barrier to adoption for domain specialists encountering active inference for the first time.

A published analysis of expected-free-energy formulations states that, unlike variational free energy, the literature does not clearly identify a root definition for expected free energy, leaving antecedence among its formulations unresolved.⁴ That is a conceptual correspondence problem the Field Working Group can take up as a terminology matrix. The matrix maps how named implementations use a defined set of core terms. It does not freeze an ontology, and it does not reserve membership to people who can work the underlying mathematics.

Multiple Implementations without a Shared Comparison Protocol

Multiple software frameworks now implement active-inference or closely related variational methods, including Statistical Parametric Mapping (SPM) and its DEM toolbox at University College London, pymdp, RxInfer.jl (a related variational-inference framework), ActiveInference.jl, ForneyLab.jl, and cpp-AIF.^{5, 6, 7, 8}, as well as related toolkits for statistical inference such as Jax, NumPyro, PyTorch, and

⁴ Théophile Champion, Howard Bowman, Dimitrije Marković, and Marek Grześ, "Reframing the Expected Free Energy: Four Formulations and a Unification," *Neural Computation* 38, no. 3 (2026): 439–469, <https://doi.org/10.1162/neco.a.1491>; preprint arXiv:2402.14460.

⁵ Conor Heins, Beren Millidge, Daphne Demekas, Brennan Klein, Karl Friston, Iain D. Couzin, and Alexander Tschantz, "pymdp: A Python Library for Active Inference in Discrete State Spaces," *Journal of Open Source Software* 7, no. 73 (2022): 4098, <https://doi.org/10.21105/joss.04098>.

⁶ Dmitry Bagaev, Albert Podusenko, and Bert de Vries, "RxInfer: A Julia Package for Reactive Real-Time Bayesian Inference," *Journal of Open Source Software* 8, no. 84 (2023): 5161, <https://doi.org/10.21105/joss.05161>.

⁷ Samuel William Nehrer et al., "Introducing ActiveInference.jl: A Julia Library for Simulation and Parameter Estimation with Active Inference Models," *Entropy* 27, no. 1 (2025): 62, <https://doi.org/10.3390/e27010062>.

⁸ Bert de Vries, "Toward Design of Synthetic Active Inference Agents by Mere Mortals," arXiv:2307.14145 (2023), <https://arxiv.org/abs/2307.14145>.

Stan ⁹. Independently authored toolkits are a healthy sign. They are also the condition under which a comparison protocol becomes useful.

The pymdp maintainers report that most low-level operations are NumPy ports of SPM functions and that most of those functions have been benchmarked and validated against their SPM counterparts.¹⁰ A public, third-party, working-group-governed protocol remains useful beyond a maintainer's own validation: shared problems, tolerances, version pins, and a rule for what counts as equivalence. Establishing that protocol is a bounded technical task and a year-one object of the Field Working Group.

Domain Communities Developing in Parallel

Active inference is being applied across clinical medicine, cognitive science, robotics, economics, and other fields by communities with limited structured interchange. Domain-specific workshops and special sessions are proliferating—evidence of the field's vitality—but insights developed in each domain remain largely within that domain's literature and community channels. There is no systematic mechanism through which a clinical active-inference researcher and a robotics active-inference researcher learn what the other has discovered about implementation barriers, computational approaches, and solution strategies.

Parallel development is common in early applied fields, and many fields remain productively specialized for long periods. Domain working groups exist to find out whether enough dual-literacy interest exists to design introductory materials that speak to a domain's actual use cases, and to assess where that domain stands.¹¹

No Shared Domain-Status Picture

There is currently no public, regularly updated assessment of where active inference adoption stands across application domains—which domains have working practitioner communities, which face specific translation barriers, and which remain at theoretical awareness. The seven-stage framework in Section 7 is a proposed provisional heuristic for such an assessment. Year one asks the Field Working Group, with participating domain groups, to review, refine, and agree upon that framework so every constituted domain uses the same rubric. Each constituted domain group then produces a documented assessment of where the domain appears to stand under that rubric, based on stated evidence. That assessment is the group's analysis, not a classification imposed on the domain. The Field Working Group may compile those self-assessments into a cross-domain table. Comparable ratings are possible only if the rubric is shared across domains.

These observations describe a field at an early applied stage. Table 1 includes fields that passed through a comparable early applied period. It also includes later-stage coordination systems. The

⁹ <https://github.com/ActiveInferenceInstitute/GeneralizedNotationNotation/> contains methods for execution of identical generative models across the noted frameworks.

¹⁰ Infer-actively, "pymdp," GitHub README, accessed August 18, 2026, <https://github.com/infer-actively/pymdp/blob/master/README.md>.

¹¹ Dual literacy—competence in active inference and in a target domain—is scarce. Domain working groups exist to produce introductory materials that can generate awareness in a domain. That is an Institute cultivation purpose. An expert–practitioner complement is at least one active-inference expert and at least one domain practitioner who is actively working in the domain. That complement is a domain constitution condition because the named year-one product cannot otherwise be produced. Dual literacy in a single individual is a different fact. A dual-literate person who is actively working in the domain may satisfy both role requirements and still counts as one of the five commitments.

instructive comparison is strongest for the early cases. The question this paper puts to the community is whether a Field Working Group, and the domain working groups that meet the formation floor and the product-fit conditions, are useful and appropriate to constitute at the November 2026 Symposium, under a charter that pauses a group if the named products are not produced or not used.

3. WHAT ROADMAPPING DOES AND WHY IT MATTERS

Technology roadmapping is the structured process of establishing where a field or technology stands today, where key stakeholders agree it should go, and what intermediate steps are required to move from one to the other. The roadmap document itself is an artifact; the coordination of stakeholder expectations and investments is the outcome. A roadmap that no one acts on is worth little. A roadmap that multiple stakeholders use to orient their independent investments becomes a self-reinforcing coordination mechanism.¹²

Assessment is the first step. A domain group that has not yet said where it stands has little basis for saying where it should go. This paper therefore treats current-state assessment as year-one work and domain roadmapping as proposed year-two work for groups that complete that assessment.

Table 1 surveys fifteen cases in which structured roadmapping initiatives with organized working groups have been associated with field-level coordination. Table 2 surveys seven fields or technologies in which coordination was incomplete, delayed, or arrived after competing conventions had already formed. The cases are heterogeneous. Field-level comparisons involve too many confounding variables for strong causal inference. They are nonetheless directly instructive: across multiple fields and time periods, organized coordination sustained over years with independent governance is a recurrent association, not a demonstrated cause. The negative cases are consistent with several mechanisms, including fragmented investment and a mismatch between expectations and technical progress. They do not by themselves prove that missing working groups caused the contraction.

Three design features recur in several of the stronger success cases: the convening body was independent of competing commercial interests; governance was documented and, in many cases, open to qualified participants; and outputs were released as public goods. Those features inform the pilot's design.

CALSTART is an instructive case of staged industry cultivation around alternative-fuel vehicles. The High-Efficiency Truck Users Forum (HTUF) Hybrid Refuse Working Group is a closer conditions case for a bounded technical group: it had a specified object, independent implementers, and purchase-ready users.^{13, 14}

¹² Robert Phaal, Clare J. P. Farrukh, and David R. Probert, "Technology Roadmapping—A Planning Framework for Evolution and Revolution," *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* 71, no. 1–2 (2004): 5–26.

¹³ CALSTART, White Paper: High-Efficiency Truck Users Forum (HTUF) Hybrid Refuse Truck Working Group (Pasadena, CA: CALSTART, January 8, 2013), <https://calstart.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/10/HTUF-Hybrid-Refuse-Truck-working-Group.pdf>.

¹⁴ CALSTART was founded in 1992, after California's Zero-Emission Vehicle mandate. HTUF Hybrid Refuse had a specified vehicle class, purchase-ready municipal users, and named manufacturers. That is the instructive conditions case. Organizational membership, voucher-program dollars, and administered public programs are treated here as organizational facts, separate from working-group impact.

Table 1. Roadmapping and Working Group Coordination: Success Cases

Fifteen cases in which independent convening, structured working groups, and published roadmaps were associated with field-level coordination. Assessments in the final column are source-bound. They are not independent causal evaluations. The Coordination structure column reports the nearest published unit (working groups, centers, projects), not a single unit type. The table is a historical record from which design lessons can be drawn.

Industry / Domain	Facilitating Organization	Working Groups	Outputs	Time Frame	Assessment of Impact
Semiconductors / ITRS	SIA / SEMATECH (NTRS); International SEMATECH (ITRS)	13 ITWGs (2003 edition)	Annual releases; full editions in odd years, specifying transistor density, power, and cost targets	1998 – 2015 (IRDS thereafter)	Coordinated R&D across five sponsoring regions; Moore's Law treated as a coordinated commitment. ¹⁵
Genomics / Human Genome Project	NIH / DOE (US); international consortium	20 research centers across 3 continents	Chromosome assignments; public milestone tracking; GenBank; finished sequence (2003)	1990 – 2003	Finished ahead of the 2003 goal and under the announced budget, per contemporaneous HGP planning. ¹⁶
Evidence-Based Medicine / GRADE	GRADE Working Group	120+ organizational users (from 2000)	GRADE evidence-quality framework (2004–present)	1996 – present	Method paper 2008; GRADE Working Group reports 120+ organizational users. WHO, NICE, and CDC are later adopters of the method, sourced separately from the 2008 paper. ¹⁷
Project Management / PMI	Project Management Institute	Multiple standards committees	PMBOK Guide (7 editions, 1987–2021); PMP certification	1987 – present	PMP recognized across many countries; knowledge framework used as a shared professional reference. ¹⁸
Evidence Synthesis / Cochrane	Cochrane	52 review groups (in transition)	Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews	1993 – present	International contributor network, now transitioning from 52 review groups to Evidence Synthesis Units; reviews widely cited in clinical guidelines. ¹⁹

¹⁵ Semiconductor Industry Association and SEMATECH, The National Technology Roadmap for Semiconductors (San Jose, CA: Semiconductor Industry Association, 1994); International Technology Roadmap for Semiconductors, International Technology Roadmap for Semiconductors: 2003 Edition, Executive Summary (2003 SEMATECH, 2003).

¹⁶ Francis S. Collins et al., "New Goals for the U.S. Human Genome Project: 1998–2003," *Science* 282, no. 5389 (1998): 682–689.

¹⁷ Gordon H. Guyatt et al., "GRADE: An Emerging Consensus on Rating Quality of Evidence and Strength of Recommendations," *BMJ* 336, no. 7650 (2008): 924–926; GRADE Working Group, accessed 2026, <https://www.gradeworkinggroup.org/>; David L. Sackett et al., "Evidence-Based Medicine: What It Is and What It Isn't," *BMJ* 312, no. 7023 (1996): 71–72.

¹⁸ Project Management Institute, A Guide to the Project Management Body of Knowledge (PMBOK Guide), 7th ed. (Newtown Square, PA: Project Management Institute, 2021).

¹⁹ Cochrane, "About Cochrane," accessed 2026, <https://www.cochrane.org/about-us>; Future of Cochrane, home page, <https://futurecochrane.org/>.

Industry / Domain	Facilitating Organization	Working Groups	Outputs	Time Frame	Assessment of Impact
Retail / Supply Chain / GS1	GS1	Sector working groups; member organisations in 118 countries	EAN barcode; GTIN; EDI; GS1 Healthcare standards	1974 – present	Broad commercial adoption of shared identification standards. ²⁰
Clean Transportation / CALSTART	CALSTART (nonprofit consortium)	WGs including HTUF Hybrid Refuse	Technology roadmaps; policy recommendations; specified vehicle-class work in HTUF	1992 – present	Instructive as a case of staged industry cultivation. Organizational membership and administered programs are not working-group impact metrics. HTUF Hybrid Refuse had a specified object and independent implementers. ^{21, 22, 23}
Mobile Communications / 3GPP	3GPP; 7 partner SDOs	16 WGs (RAN, SA, CT)	3G, 4G/LTE, 5G NR specifications adopted as ITU standards	1998 – present	Unified mobile specifications used globally. ²⁴
Health IT / HL7-FHIR	Health Level Seven International	Multiple WGs for FHIR resources	HL7 messaging; FHIR R4; US Core profiles	1987 – present	Referenced in U.S. interoperability policy and used internationally. ²⁵
Climate Science / IPCC	IPCC (UN)	3 main WGs	Six Assessment Reports (1990–2023); Special Reports	1988 – present	Scientific basis for UNFCCC instruments; shared 2007 Nobel Peace Prize. ²⁶
Open Source / Linux Foundation	Linux Foundation	Many hosted projects	Linux kernel; OpenSSF; SPDX	2000 – present	Large multi-firm membership and hosted public infrastructure. Organizational revenue is not a working-group impact metric. ²⁷
IT Governance / ISACA-COBIT	ISACA	Standards and framework committees	COBIT v1.0 (1996) through later editions; credentials	1996 – present	COBIT used as an IT governance reference; credentials recognized alongside other frameworks. ²⁸
Engineering Standards / IEEE	IEEE Standards Association	More than 500 active working groups	IEEE 802.11, 802.3, 1547, and others	IEEE 1963–present (AIEE 1884); SA working-group process later	IEEE standards widely referenced in regulation and procurement. ²⁹

²⁰ GS1, "About GS1," accessed 2026, <https://www.gs1.org/about>.

²¹ CALSTART, "About CALSTART," accessed 2026, <https://calstart.org/about/>.

²² CALSTART, White Paper: High-Efficiency Truck Users Forum (HTUF) Hybrid Refuse Truck Working Group.

²³ California Air Resources Board, "About the Zero-Emission Vehicle Program," <https://ww2.arb.ca.gov/our-work/programs/zero-emission-vehicle-program/about>.

²⁴ 3GPP, "About 3GPP," accessed 2026, <https://www.3gpp.org/about-3gpp>.

²⁵ Health Level Seven International, FHIR and related standards documentation; 21st Century Cures Act interoperability rule context as commonly cited in ONC materials.

²⁶ Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change, "About the IPCC," accessed 2026, <https://www.ipcc.ch/about/>.

²⁷ Linux Foundation, 2025 Annual Report (San Francisco: Linux Foundation, 2025).

²⁸ ISACA, Control Objectives for Information and Related Technologies (COBIT), Version 1.0 (Rolling Meadows, IL: ISACA, 1996).

²⁹ IEEE Standards Association, "How Are Standards Developed?," accessed August 25, 2026, <https://standards.ieee.org/beyond-standards/how-standards-are-made/>.

Industry / Domain	Facilitating Organization	Working Groups	Outputs	Time Frame	Assessment of Impact
Web Standards / W3C	World Wide Web Consortium	50+ active WGs	HTML5; CSS; WebAssembly; ARIA; XML; SVG	1994 – present	Specifications implemented across major browsers. ³⁰
Internet Standards / IETF	Internet Engineering Task Force	100+ active WGs across 7 areas	RFCs; TCP/IP stack; HTTP; TLS; DNS; SMTP; BGP	1986 – present	Rough-consensus-and-running-code model; RFC 2418 is the procedural model cited in this paper. ³¹

Table 2. Coordination Gaps and Adverse Development Outcomes

Seven cases in which gaps in independent coordination, shared standards, or community-calibrated milestones are associated with adverse development outcomes. Each case involves multiple contributing factors. Coordination gaps are a common structural thread, not a sole cause. The table is a historical record from which design lessons can be drawn.

Field / Technology	Time Period	Coordination Gap	Consequences	Source
Artificial Intelligence (First Wave)	1974 – 1980	No standing field body to calibrate expectations; research fragmented; Lighthill Report (1973) challenged credibility. Replies appeared in the same SRC volume; a June 1973 debate was televised	UK SRC funding contracted; US AI funding was reoriented in the Mansfield era. The cited Nilsson history does not say DARPA withdrew AI funding because of Lighthill	Lighthill (1973); Nilsson (2010). ³²
Artificial Intelligence (Second Wave / Expert Systems)	1987 – 1993	LISP-machine vendors lost out to general-purpose workstations; expert systems developed in silos	Expert-systems market contracted; companies disbanded AI divisions. Nilsson attributes the hardware decline to workstation competition, not missing standards	Nilsson (2010). ³³
Virtual Reality (First Wave)	1990 – 1995	Competing incompatible systems; no shared-evaluation mechanism is documented in the sources cited here	Market collapsed by 1995; major vendors exited; consumer VR dormant for about two decades	Interpretive reading of Rheingold (1991) and Bailenson (2018); not a source-bound mechanism claim. ³⁴

³⁰ World Wide Web Consortium, W3C Process Document, 2023.

³¹ Bradner, "IETF Working Group Guidelines and Procedures," RFC 2418.

³² James Lighthill, "Artificial Intelligence: A General Survey," in Artificial Intelligence: A Paper Symposium (London: Science Research Council, 1973); Nils J. Nilsson, The Quest for Artificial Intelligence: A History of Ideas and Achievements (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010).

³³ Nilsson, Quest for Artificial Intelligence.

³⁴ Howard Rheingold, Virtual Reality (New York: Summit Books, 1991); Jeremy Bailenson, Experience on Demand (New York: Norton, 2018).

Field / Technology	Time Period	Coordination Gap	Consequences	Source
Gene Therapy (Pre-2000)	1990 – 2000	No field-wide safety standards or coordinated adverse-event reporting; programs advanced without shared clinical protocols	Distinct episodes: Jesse Gelsinger death (1999); FDA halted Penn's IHGT program (Jan. 2000); FDA placed about 27 retroviral hematopoietic-stem-cell trials on hold (Jan. 2003)	Stolberg (1999); Maugh / Los Angeles Times (2003). ^{35, 36}
Enterprise Blockchain / Supply Chain	2017–2023	Competing platforms; enterprise pilots remained siloed; participation and financing did not hold	Maersk and IBM discontinued TradeLens (29 Nov. 2022; offline by end of Q1 2023), citing the absence of full global industry collaboration. We.trade discontinued after shareholders could not agree new financing.	Reuters (2022); Wragg / Global Trade Review (2022). ^{37, 38}
Electronic Health Records (Pre-Interoperability)	1990s–2009	Hundreds of EHR systems with proprietary formats; HL7 v2 adoption voluntary and inconsistent; no body with mandate to require interoperability	HITECH Act (2009) financed EHR adoption and Meaningful Use; later Cures Act rules addressed interoperability	ONC Report to Congress (January 2012). ³⁹
High-Definition Television / MUSE (Analog Era)	1987–2000	Japan developed MUSE analog HDTV unilaterally; US, Europe, and Japan pursued incompatible standards	MUSE obsolete before wide deployment; resolved when digital ATSC provided a common framework	Hart (1994); FCC Advisory Committee (1995). ⁴⁰

³⁵ Sheryl Gay Stolberg, "The Biotech Death of Jesse Gelsinger," New York Times Magazine, November 28, 1999.

³⁶ Thomas H. Maugh II, "Citing Illnesses, FDA Halts Gene Therapy Trials," Los Angeles Times, January 15, 2003, <https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-2003-jan-15-sci-gene15-story.html>.

³⁷ Reuters, "Maersk, IBM Discontinue Shipping Blockchain Platform," November 29, 2022, <https://www.reuters.com/technology/maersk-ibm-discontinue-shipping-blockchain-platform-2022-11-29/>.

³⁸ Eleanor Wragg, "We.trade Calls It Quits after Running Out of Cash," Global Trade Review, June 6, 2022, <https://www.gtreview.com/news/top-stories/we-trade-calls-it-quits-after-running-out-of-cash/>.

³⁹ Office of the National Coordinator for Health Information Technology, Update on the Adoption of Health Information Technology and Related Efforts to Facilitate the Electronic Use and Exchange of Health Information: A Report to Congress (Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, January 2012), <https://healthit.gov/wp-content/uploads/2018/03/january-2012-update-on-hit-adoption-report-to-congress.pdf>.

⁴⁰ Jeffrey Hart, "The Politics of HDTV in the United States," Policy Studies Journal 22, no. 2 (1994): 213–228, <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1541-0072.1994.tb01464.x>; FCC Advisory Committee on Advanced Television Service, Final Report and Recommendation, November 28, 1995; Federal Communications Commission, Fourth Report and Order, FCC 96-493, December 27, 1996, https://transition.fcc.gov/Bureaus/Mass_Media/Orders/1996/fcc96493.pdf.

4. THE CASE FOR COMPARISON, ASSESSMENT, AND DOMAIN ROADMAPPING

Roadmapping activity for active inference is already underway, distributed across research programs, company technology strategies, grant proposals, and individual research agendas. Some of that activity will remain proprietary. A company's roadmap describes where that company plans to go. Those roadmaps will continue. Year one adds a public way to compare implementations and a shared way to assess domains.

Isolated laboratory and company work can produce excellent tools. A public comparison protocol, version pins, and an agreed rule for what counts as equivalence are field-level objects. Correspondence is stratified: conceptual (same terms), algorithmic (same update), and numerical (same computed values only where the computations correspond). No single laboratory has both the incentive and the standing to maintain them as a public good. That is a year-one object of the Field Working Group: a terminology correspondence note and a public comparison protocol.

The object is bounded on purpose. Consensus processes can coordinate where markets stall, at the cost of time; they can also lock in an inferior specification or delay a better one.^{41, 42, 43} Year one therefore produces a comparison object the field can use or discard. Larger coordination—standards, a field-wide path to practitioner deployment—belongs later, after the field has more evidence.

Because that object compares independently authored implementations, the convener should have no direct commercial stake in one of them. That is a reason for a neutral Field convener.

Another year-one object of the Field Working Group is a shared domain-assessment framework. Section 7 proposes a seven-stage heuristic as the framework's starting point. The ecosystem may adopt that text provisionally at the Symposium or thereafter. The Field Working Group then reviews, refines, and agrees the framework, with constituted domain groups participating so that the people who will use the rubric have a hand in writing it. Each constituted domain group sends one or two people to that series, or those people join the Field group as ordinary members for that workstream. The Field group records concurrence from each constituted domain group before it adopts the framework. Concurrence means no sustained objection. If no domain group forms, the Field group may still adopt a framework for later use.

After adoption, each domain group applies that same framework to its own domain and writes that group's assessment. The Field group may compile those self-assessments into a cross-domain table. Apple-to-apple comparison requires a shared rubric; the ratings themselves remain the domain's.

Literacy work and the implementation-comparison protocol run in parallel with the framework series. Completing the shared framework is collaboration on method. It does not, by itself, warrant continuation of every domain group.

⁴¹ Joseph Farrell and Garth Saloner, "Standardization, Compatibility, and Innovation," *RAND Journal of Economics* 16, no. 1 (1985): 70–83, http://sjbae.pbworks.com/w/file/41532753/farrell_saloner_1985.pdf.

⁴² Paul A. David and Shane Greenstein, "The Economics of Compatibility Standards: An Introduction to Recent Research," *Economics of Innovation and New Technology* 1, no. 1–2 (1990): 3–41, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10438599000000002>.

⁴³ Joseph Farrell and Timothy Simcoe, "Choosing the Rules for Consensus Standardization," *RAND Journal of Economics* 43, no. 2 (2012): 235–252, <https://people.bu.edu/tsimcoe/documents/published/ConsensusRules.pdf>.

Domain roadmapping is proposed as year-two work for groups that complete an assessment. The paper recommends that sequence. Each group decides whether to take it up. Subsequent years are a new decision.

5. THE CASE FOR AN ECOSYSTEM WORKING GROUP STRUCTURE

Section 4 named the objects of work: a terminology correspondence matrix, a comparison protocol, a shared assessment framework, domain literacy materials, initial domain assessments, and—later, if a group so decides—domain roadmaps. This section asks which organizational form is appropriate for that work. An open, chartered, task-bounded working group is the form whose design properties—open participation, public process, chartered scope, iterative output, and independence from a single sponsor—fit the Field job. A lighter, time-bounded variant of the same form can host domain working groups.

The warrant for constituting groups includes terminology correspondence, a shared assessment method, domain assessment, literacy and education materials, and later domain roadmapping. Demonstrated interoperability failure is one possible later warrant. Year-one work proceeds without it.

5.1 Scope of This Comparison

This subsection compares organizational forms for two different jobs. The Field Working Group is a body that can maintain a comparison protocol and a terminology map across independently authored implementations, and that can hold the pen on a shared assessment framework. Domain working groups are bodies that can put active-inference experts and domain practitioners in the same room long enough to produce a literacy product, an initial domain assessment, and a go/no-go on the group's continuation.

5.2 Alternative Organizational Forms

Single Standing Committee or Oversight Board

A standing committee, as used here, is a small fixed-membership deliberative body charged with setting policy or managing shared resources. In theory it offers clarity of authority and lower overhead than distributed bodies. A small fixed board is poorly suited to Field comparison work without the people who actually maintain the implementations, and is poorly suited to domain work without the domain practitioners the Board does not already contain. Laboratory studies of social loafing and process loss are a general caution about group size.^{44, 45}

Annual Symposium and Conference Model

The annual symposium is the field's existing primary gathering: the International Workshop on Active Inference has convened annually since 2020, and the AII Symposium since 2021. Conferences establish shared vocabulary, surface competing approaches, and catalyze informal collaborations.⁴⁶

⁴⁴Bibb Latané, Kipling Williams, and Stephen Harkins, "Many Hands Make Light the Work: The Causes and Consequences of Social Loafing," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 37, no. 6 (1979): 822–832.

⁴⁵Ivan D. Steiner, *Group Process and Productivity* (New York: Academic Press, 1972).

⁴⁶Diana Crane, *Invisible Colleges: Diffusion of Knowledge in Scientific Communities* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972).

They are episodic. A comparison protocol, a terminology map, an assessment framework, and a literacy module require iteration between annual meetings. The existing symposium is therefore the founding venue for the groups and the Institute's annual meeting place for them. The symposium is complementary Institute infrastructure. Working groups may meet there. They do not convene it. The symposium does not sit inside the working-group structure, nor vice versa.

Proprietary or Closed Research Group

Closed research environments have produced major technical achievements, including the transistor and information theory at Bell Laboratories.⁴⁷ A public comparison object and a shared assessment method are public-process work. A proprietary coordination model would leave a single organization determining what counts as valid active inference. Open-innovation arguments about knowledge leakage and complement strategies show that even firms that invest in open infrastructure remain subject to proprietary constraints.^{48, 49}

Appointed Expert Panel

The appointed expert panel is the canonical form for field-wide scientific assessment. It is well suited to a commissioned synthesis. Appointment processes reflect the appointing body's network.⁵⁰ A panel can be the right form for a one-time state-of-the-field review. The Field object's work is closer to a persistent, rechartered task group than to a panel that convenes, reports, and dissolves.

Competitive Prize and Challenge Model

Prize and challenge competitions direct effort toward specified targets. They are the right tool when the evaluation criterion is already agreed.^{51, 52} Adding competitors helps more when the problem is highly uncertain and can reduce effort when it is not.⁵³ A bounded cross-platform comparison of SPM, pymdp, and RxInfer.jl is the most clearly specified current technical problem in this field. A prize or challenge is an appropriate deliverable format for that problem. The body that writes the protocol, pins the versions, and publishes the result is a separate instrument. The relationship is complementary.

Centralized Research Institute or Center

Centralized institutes concentrate resources and produce some coordination as a byproduct of proximity. Two different roles travel under the word "institute," and they should be kept apart.

An institute that writes and owns the comparison object, and that also defines the field, concentrates authority in one organization. Open-source leadership arguments imply that contributors will

⁴⁷ Jon Gertner, *The Idea Factory: Bell Labs and the Great Age of American Innovation* (New York: Penguin Press, 2012).

⁴⁸ Henry W. Chesbrough, *Open Innovation: The New Imperative for Creating and Profiting from Technology* (Boston: Harvard Business School Press, 2003).

⁴⁹ Joel West and Scott Gallagher, "Challenges of Open Innovation: The Paradox of Firm Investment in Open-Source Software," *R&D Management* 36, no. 3 (2006): 319–331.

⁵⁰ Sheila Jasanoff, *The Fifth Branch: Science Advisers as Policymakers* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1990).

⁵¹ Sabrina Adamczyk, Angelika C. Bullinger, and Kathrin M. Möslin, "Innovation Contests: A Review, Classification and Outlook," *Creativity and Innovation Management* 21, no. 4 (2012): 335–360.

⁵² Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency, "Grand Challenge," <https://www.darpa.mil/about/innovation-timeline/grand-challenge>.

⁵³ Kevin J. Boudreau, Nicola Lacetera, and Karim R. Lakhani, "Incentives and Problem Uncertainty in Innovation Contests: An Empirical Analysis," *Management Science* 57, no. 5 (2011): 843–863.

withhold shared infrastructure if they believe its steward is an interested party.⁵⁴ Neutrality, on that evidence, is a function of who writes the object and who can block it.

An institute that convenes open, member-constituted groups and publishes what those groups adopt is a different role. The groups own the substance. The institute hosts process, imprint, and archive. AII is proposing the second role.

5.3 The Open Working-Group Model

Open working groups—as practiced, with important membership differences, by the IETF, W3C, IEEE, HL7, 3GPP, and GS1—are persistent bodies organized around a specified objective, operating under a written charter, with transparent process and public outputs. IETF and W3C participation is comparatively open; 3GPP membership is mediated by Organizational Partners. This proposal uses the more open variant: any individual with relevant expertise or substantive interest may join. The academic literature on standard-setting organizations is the most rigorous evidence base for this model, used here for the narrower claim those papers actually support.

Simcoe's study of IETF committees finds that delay increases as private-sector participation and distributional conflict rise.⁵⁵ Farrell and Saloner compare committees, market leadership, and a hybrid; in their model the committee is slower than the market but more likely to achieve coordination.⁵⁶ Farrell and Simcoe model consensus standardization as a war of attrition that can screen for quality but imposes delay when vested interests block compromise.⁵⁷ Taken together, these papers support a narrower claim than broad adoption superiority. They show that consensus bodies can coordinate where markets stall, at the cost of time, and that delay rises when private stakes arrive.

That finding is a warrant for the Field comparison object. It is one warrant among others for the pilot as a whole. Domain groups stand on literacy, domain assessment, later domain roadmapping, and—when a group takes it up—review of educational materials for domain fit. Awareness and adoption inside a domain are legitimate working-group functions. So is helping course developers adapt materials to the readiness and use cases of that domain.

Commons-based peer production is an analogy for modular knowledge goods such as a comparison protocol or a glossary.⁵⁸ User-innovation research is a reason to keep domain groups open to practitioners.⁵⁹ Influence inside formal working groups can concentrate among better-resourced

⁵⁴ Josh Lerner and Jean Tirole, "Some Simple Economics of Open Source," *Journal of Industrial Economics* 50, no. 2 (2002): 197–234.

⁵⁵ Timothy S. Simcoe, "Standard Setting Committees: Consensus Governance for Shared Technology Platforms," *American Economic Review* 102, no. 1 (2012): 305–336.

⁵⁶ Joseph Farrell and Garth Saloner, "Coordination through Committees and Markets," *RAND Journal of Economics* 19, no. 2 (1988): 235–252.

⁵⁷ Joseph Farrell and Timothy Simcoe, "Choosing the Rules for Consensus Standardization."

⁵⁸ Yochai Benkler, *The Wealth of Networks: How Social Production Transforms Markets and Freedom* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2006).

⁵⁹ Eric von Hippel, *Democratizing Innovation* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2005), <https://web.mit.edu/evhippel/www/books/DI/DemocInn.pdf>.

participants; open communities also develop formal authority and then have to constrain it.^{60, 61} Those findings inform the independence provisions, the self-dissolve rule, and the facilitation-withdrawal provisions in the Charter.

RFC 2418 requires an IETF working group to have a written charter that states the problem, goals, and milestones as specific deliverables, and treats working groups as task-bounded bodies that are rechartered or disbanded when the task ends or cannot be completed.⁶² That is the procedural model this proposal follows.

5.4 Comparative Summary

Table 3 is a qualitative summary of the argument in Sections 5.2 and 5.3. It has no independent source.

Table 3. Organizational forms compared with the Field and domain jobs in this proposal

Organizational form	Fit for Field WG (comparison, terminology, shared framework)	Fit for domain WGs (literacy and assessment)	Key limitation
Standing committee	Weak	Weak	Fixed membership; excludes implementers and domain practitioners
Annual symposium	Complementary	Complementary	Episodic founding venue and annual meeting place; not a standing work body
Proprietary or closed group	Poor	Poor	Concentrates authority; IP barriers
Appointed expert panel	One-time review only	Poor	Appointment-dependence; thin iteration
Prize or challenge	Complementary tool	Poor	Requires a specified criterion; no standing protocol
Institute as author and owner of the object	Poor	Poor	Concentrates field authority
Institute as convener and publisher of open groups	Fit; this proposal	Fit; this proposal	Requires independence controls
Open, task-bounded working group	Best available form	Acceptable form if time-bounded	Requires organizing capacity and capture-control provisions

5.5 Recommendation

The comparison supports recommending an open, chartered, task-bounded working-group structure as the form for the Field Working Group, and a time-bounded variant of the same form for domain working groups. The annual symposium remains the Institute's gathering and the groups' annual meeting place. A bounded challenge and a commissioned expert panel remain available tools. They sit alongside the working groups.

⁶⁰ Aija Leiponen, "Competing Through Cooperation: The Organization of Standard Setting in Wireless Telecommunications," *Management Science* 54, no. 11 (2008): 1904–1919.

⁶¹ Siobhán O'Mahony and Fabrizio Ferraro, "The Emergence of Governance in an Open Source Community," *Academy of Management Journal* 50, no. 5 (2007): 1079–1106.

⁶² Scott Bradner, "IETF Working Group Guidelines and Procedures," RFC 2418 (Internet Engineering Task Force, 1998), <https://www.rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc2418>.

Three design features distinguish groups that can be evaluated from those that cannot.

First, scope precision. Groups fail when participants have not agreed on mission, goals, terms, and utility. Failure modes include deadlock, feature creep, market indifference, and incompatible implementations.⁶³ This proposal specifies a twelve-month pilot, named year-one products for the Field group and for each domain group, and gate conditions for groups' continuation.

Second, independence controls. To avoid capture, the independence provisions, the self-dissolve rule, the facilitation-withdrawal provisions, and the pre-stated stop rule in Article XII are structural controls. A Section 2 confirmation cannot waive them.

Third, convener neutrality. AII's role is administrative, not epistemic. Board authorship of this proposal is disclosed in the front matter.

The case is theoretical and design-based. Whether the form performs is an empirical question, to be answered by the twelve-month pilot and the stop rule.

6. WHY THE ACTIVE INFERENCE INSTITUTE

The Active Inference Institute was established as a 501(c)(3) nonprofit with the mission of translating the science of active inference into practical tools, resources, and educational experiences accessible to diverse audiences. Independence from commercial interests, for a convening body in this role, requires structural separation between revenue-generating activities and the governance of the coordination function. IEEE and PMI are familiar examples of organizations that separate revenue-generating activity from the governance of a technical or knowledge product. The comparison is limited: those organizations operate at a different scale. AII's nonprofit structure provides a workable basis for the same kind of separation: the mission is served by the field's advancement broadly.

The proposed activities align with the Institute's published vision and mission.

Vision: A world where active inference, a framework of adaptive behavior grounded in first principles, is known, taught, and applied across science, engineering, and everyday life.

Mission: To translate the science of how natural systems adapt and self-organize, known as active inference, into practical tools, resources, and educational experiences that empower people, communities, and technology to enhance decision making and reduce uncertainty.

Several characteristics of AII's current position make AII able to initiate and administratively support this pilot. The case for constituting the groups is in Sections 2, 4, 5, and 8. This section states why AII is a plausible convener.

Scientific Advisory Capacity

AII maintains a Scientific Advisory Board of more than thirty members drawn from the research communities actively contributing to active inference theory and application. Working groups

⁶³ Carl F. Cargill, "Why Standardization Efforts Fail," *Journal of Electronic Publishing* 14, no. 1 (2011), <https://doi.org/10.3998/3336451.0014.103>.

organized under AII's auspices have direct access to research expertise spanning relevant domains. SAB members may contribute scientific expertise to working groups if they volunteer. The SAB is not a scientific court and does not clear working-group outputs for validity. Implementer participation on the Field Working Group and domain-practitioner participation on domain groups remain the product-fit conditions. SAB members may volunteer to join a domain group as regular members to supply the active-inference expert role if a candidate domain otherwise lacks one. They join by volunteering. They are not assigned.

Existing Coordination Infrastructure

AII has convened the global active inference community annually for six years through its Applied Active Inference Symposium. AII maintains an ecosystem and mailing list of more than 2,000 members and a recorded archive of more than 700 videos produced over more than five years (AII institutional record, August 2026). This infrastructure is an existing coordination mechanism that no single research institution or company currently replicates. It is the reason a November 2026 founding session is feasible.

A core design principle of the proposed structure is to minimize the human labor required to sustain coordination infrastructure. AII has invested in a technology stack that supports asynchronous collaboration at low marginal cost: Superhuman for collaboration and the working information repository; Superhuman for task management; GitHub for asynchronous document development and public transparency; and AI-assisted meeting capture for published records. The AII Liaison is a support function.

Development Stage Alignment

An independent convening organization often adds the most value during the transition from theoretical elaboration to applied deployment. Most fields where active inference is beginning to take hold are at Stage 1 (Theoretical Awareness) or Stage 2 (Domain Translation) of the heuristic in Section 7. Domain groups exist because dual literacy is scarce and introductory materials, plus an honest stage assessment, are useful where it is scarce.

Mission Alignment with Field-Level Interests

AII has no direct commercial stake in any particular application of active inference or any specific implementation approach. Its mission is served when the field advances broadly. Universities command research credibility but carry institutional affiliation. Newly formed bodies would lack six years of community presence. Commercial organizations face a credibility problem when they convene a field-level comparison of implementations, because they typically have a stake in one of those implementations. AII can initiate a pilot and demonstrate value through action. Credibility is to be earned through the quality and openness of the work.

Governance Safeguards Built into the Proposed Structure

The proposed structure incorporates safeguards drawn from the coordination bodies reviewed in Table 1. These are design requirements for a pilot whose value depends on credibility with the full active inference community.

- **Open membership.** Any individual with relevant expertise or substantive interest may join a working group; membership requires no financial contribution and no prior AII affiliation. Membership is not reserved to people who can work the underlying mathematics.
- **Consensus-seeking decision process.** Working groups are required to seek consensus before proceeding to formal votes, and dissenting views are preserved in the official record.
- **Conflict of interest disclosure and recusal.** A member recuses when the group reviews materials produced by that member's own organization. Financial contribution to AII, including donation, is not a condition of membership, speaking, or participation.
- **AII Liaison oversight.** The AII Board appoints a non-voting Liaison.
- **Exclusive official publication by AII.** Official working-group outputs are published by the Institute. Technical and scientific content remains the working group's responsibility. AII review is limited to institutional policy, accuracy of institutional representations, and license terms. Individual authors may publish their own independent papers anywhere. Official outputs are free to working-group participants. The comparison protocol, the terminology note, and the assessment framework remain public under CC BY 4.0. The Board may later authorize a nominal charge to non-participants, or a more restrictive license, for other official outputs.
- **Inactive-group intervention.** AII may suspend its facilitation and publication for a group that fails to maintain activity standards after notice. AII may not dissolve a working group. A group may dissolve itself. AII may withdraw as convener. Withdrawal does not dissolve any group. Existence of a group is not contingent on AII remaining convener. The groups are assumed not to be separate legal persons.
- Year-one stop rule and twelve-month pilot evaluation, in addition to a five-year sunset review. Continuation requires the named products.

Structural Note: How the Working Group System Relates to Active Inference Theory

Active inference is an account of how adaptive systems maintain coherence with their environment by continuously reducing the gap between a generative model's predictions and the evidence the system actually receives. The Field and domain structure proposed here is a structural analogy at the field level.

The Field Working Group is closer to a sensory channel: it gathers evidence about whether independently authored implementations correspond, and it holds a shared method for reading the state of each domain. Domain working groups are closer to directed action in a niche: a domain community assesses where it stands, designs literacy materials in its own terms, and—if it chooses after that assessment—writes a domain roadmap. The seven-stage framework is a structured prior, used here as a developmental heuristic—a structured expectation about how domain-level integration typically develops, to be updated or discarded as evidence accumulates.

This is a structural analogy and organizing heuristic, not a formal theoretical claim about field-level cognitive processes. Whether the parallel has implications for understanding federated inference,

collective cognition, and institutional development more broadly is a question the authors commend to the theoretical community's attention.

7. THE PROPOSED ASSESSMENT FRAMEWORK

A Proposed Seven-Stage Domain Development Framework

Stage-based frameworks for tracking how technologies and practices mature through adoption cycles have a well-documented record across disciplines. The diffusion of innovations literature describes technologies and practices spreading through populations in patterns often summarized as an S-curve.⁶⁴ Technology readiness level frameworks, first formalized by NASA in 1995, extended stage-based maturity assessment into a structured scale for evaluating whether a technology is ready for application.⁶⁵ The Capability Maturity Model established that organizational capability develops through identifiable stages with characteristic gate conditions.⁶⁶ Gartner's Hype Cycle is a practitioner illustration of inflated expectations and a trough of disillusionment, not a research finding. The AI winters and the VR collapse in Table 2 are historical cases, not evidence that the Hype Cycle is a general law.⁶⁷ Dreyfus and Dreyfus established that skill acquisition at the individual level follows a five-stage progression from novice to expert.⁶⁸

This paper proposes a seven-stage domain development framework as a provisional working heuristic. The stage boundaries and sequencing are informed by the historical cases reviewed above. They have yet to be independently validated across a systematic sample of field-development cases. Stages frequently overlap. Individual domains may skip stages, stall, or return to earlier stages. The Symposium may adopt the framework provisionally as the starting text for year one. The Field Working Group, with participating domain groups, then reviews, refines, and agrees the version the domains will use.

The framework's central analytical claim is that domain-level integration of active inference is a sequence of distinct developmental stages, each with characteristic barriers and gate conditions. Attempting to skip gate conditions—establishing credentialing programs before educational infrastructure exists, or developing professional standards before a practitioner community has formed—produces frameworks with no one to use them.

Stage 1: Theoretical Awareness

Domain practitioners and researchers have encountered active inference in conference presentations, adjacent-field literature, or scientific reporting, but no systematic effort to explore its applicability within the domain has been undertaken. No researchers with dual literacy in active inference and the target domain are publishing domain-specific work. The barrier is primarily unfamiliarity. Illustrative duration, highly domain-dependent: 1–3 years; stages may overlap.

⁶⁴ Everett M. Rogers, *Diffusion of Innovations*, 5th ed. (New York: Free Press, 2003).

⁶⁵ John C. Mankins, "Technology Readiness Levels," NASA White Paper, April 6, 1995.

⁶⁶ Mark C. Paulk, Bill Curtis, Mary Beth Chrissis, and Charles V. Weber, *Capability Maturity Model for Software*, Version 1.1, CMU/SEI-93-TR-024 (Pittsburgh: Software Engineering Institute, Carnegie Mellon University, 1993).

⁶⁷ Jackie Fenn and Mark Raskino, *Mastering the Hype Cycle: How to Choose the Right Innovation at the Right Time* (Boston: Harvard Business Press, 2008).

⁶⁸ Stuart E. Dreyfus and Hubert L. Dreyfus, "A Five-Stage Model of the Mental Activities Involved in Directed Skill Acquisition," ORC 80-2 (Berkeley: Operations Research Center, University of California, February 1980).

Stage 2: Domain Translation

A small number of researchers with competency in both active inference and the target domain have begun systematic work to translate core theoretical concepts into domain-relevant language, problems, and preliminary models. Publications specific to the domain begin to appear. The gate condition is the emergence of at least one researcher with genuine domain fluency publishing active-inference work that domain practitioners can recognize as engaging their field's actual problems. Illustrative duration: 1–3 years.

Stage 3: Community Nucleation

A nascent community of domain-focused active-inference researchers and practitioners forms and begins to self-organize. The gate condition is at least one recurring venue that provides continuity across individual contributors. Illustrative duration: 1–2 years.

Stage 4: Educational Infrastructure

Courses, curricula, and structured learning resources specific to active inference in the domain become available. The gate condition is at least one formal educational pathway that a motivated domain practitioner could follow to acquire foundational competency. Illustrative duration: 1–3 years.

Stage 5: Credentialing and Practitioner Market

Employer demand for practitioners trained in active-inference methods becomes sufficiently visible to sustain credentialing frameworks. The gate condition is documented, verifiable employer demand—expressed interest alone is insufficient. Where that demand does not develop, Stage 5 may remain out of reach on any predictable timeline.

Stage 6: Standards, Auditing, and Professional Events

The domain's practice community is large and stable enough to sustain professional standards development. The gate condition requires a practitioner community of sufficient scale and institutional backing to sustain a multi-year standards process. Stage 6 is a later-horizon marker for groups constituted in 2026.

Stage 7: Institutional Maturity

Active-inference methods are embedded in the domain's professional standards, taught in mainstream educational programs, and expected of practitioners in relevant specializations. Stage 7 is an open-ended condition.

Most candidate domains, if they form at all, will be at Stage 1 or Stage 2. Their year-one job is a literacy product, an initial assessment against the agreed framework, and a go/no-go on the group's continuation. A domain roadmap from the assessed stage toward later stages is proposed as year-two work.

8. THE PROPOSED WORKING GROUP STRUCTURE

Working groups in this proposal are bounded bodies charged with a named object, operating under transparent governance, and producing outputs the field can use or discard. AII's role is convener and exclusive official publisher. Responsibility for the technical analyses, interpretations, and scientific conclusions in working-group outputs belongs to working-group members. Working groups are

constituted by their members. Withdrawal of AII as convener leaves a group intact. AII's publication review covers consistency with institutional policies, accuracy of institutional representations, and license terms.

Working-group outputs are the groups' products. Official AII policy is limited to the institutional policies described in the Charter. Adoption of an output establishes only that it represents a Working Group position. It does not establish field-wide scientific consensus, independently validated scientific findings, or an authoritative determination that an external scientific claim is valid or invalid. Independent scientific standing, if sought, requires an appropriate external peer-review process.

Working groups may form provisionally at the founding Symposium—operating under provisional terms for up to ninety days. Full Charter adoption is required before a group undertakes binding votes on final deliverables. A group that has not adopted the full Charter within ninety days of its provisional constitution shall be considered inactive.

Field Working Group and Domain Working Groups

AII proposes a Field Working Group and domain working groups. The Field group operates under the Field charter in Appendix A. Domain groups operate under charters derived from a domain-charter template. Domain charters may add supplementary provisions. They may not relax the four locked process points: open membership, publication, the shared assessment rubric, and the stop rule. That is a hierarchy, not two independent constitutions. Compatibility is a process check. Compatibility review does not extend to scientific or technical judgments of a domain group. Field products are adopted by the Field Working Group, with notice to constituted domain groups. Domain products are adopted by that domain and may be shared with other domains for their consideration.

The Field Working Group's year-one object is (a) a terminology correspondence matrix covering a defined set of core terms as used in at least SPM/DEM, pymdp, and RxInfer.jl (as a related variational-inference framework); (b) a public comparison protocol for a small set of standard problems, stratified into conceptual, algorithmic, and numerical correspondence, with version pins and a stated equivalence rule. Numerical equivalence is claimed only where the computations correspond. RxInfer.jl remains a related variational-inference framework, not a numerical-equivalence target unless the Field group later documents corresponding computations; and (c) a shared domain-assessment framework, reviewed and agreed with constituted domain groups. The Field Working Group may add independently authored implementations to the comparison set in its Year One Work Plan without a Charter amendment. Changing the named year-one object itself requires rechartering under Article II. Independent implementations supply the condition for the comparison object. Each domain group still meets its own conditions. The Field Working Group is constituted when at least five individuals have committed in writing to that object, including at least one individual who maintains or actively uses an implementation included in the initial comparison set. Representation from every named implementation is welcome.

Domain working groups form where people with a stated interest in that domain meet the formation floor (i.e. the minimum number of participants). Their year-one object is a literacy and adaptation module designed jointly by active-inference experts and domain practitioners, an initial domain assessment against the agreed framework, and a published go/no-go on whether the domain has the minimum committed membership and an expert–practitioner complement to continue. Constituted domain groups participate in the Field group's framework series so that the rubric they will use is one

they have helped to shape. Every non-deferred candidate domain that meets the formation floor and the domain participation conditions may form. There is no hard cap on the number of domain groups.

Field evidence stays with the Field group. Completing the shared framework does not constitute a domain group. Each domain group must meet the formation floor and the domain participation conditions on its own.

The Active Inference Field Working Group

The Field Working Group addresses field-level comparability and the shared assessment method. Its scope in year one is the theoretical and computational object named above, plus the assessment framework. Domain self-assessments belong to the domain groups. A compiled cross-domain table, if produced, is a Field group compilation of those self-assessments.

If, after year one, the comparison protocol is used by at least two implementation communities and receives the external review required in Article VII.6, the group may be rechartered. Rechartering is a new decision.

Domain Working Groups

Domain working groups address a single field of application. Each focuses on whether active inference can be introduced to that domain in the domain's own terms, on where the domain currently appears to stand under a stated rubric, and—in a later year, if the group so decides—on a domain roadmap. Proposed domains for possible later or year-one groups include:

- Healthcare and clinical medicine
- Neuroscience
- Mental health and psychiatry
- Education and learning science
- Artificial intelligence and AGI
- Robotics, drones, and autonomous systems
- Finance and economic decision-making
- Climate and environmental science
- Cybersecurity
- Defense and national security applications
- Logistics

Where a label above combines more than one domain, the combination is subject to change based on community feedback. The list is a suggestion list. Education and artificial intelligence remain separate candidate domains.

Several candidate domains require boundary clarification before any group is constituted. Healthcare and mental health/psychiatry share substantial terrain. Neuroscience overlaps significantly with field-level active-inference development; a neuroscience group and the Field Working Group would

require explicit scope coordination. Finance is a broad candidate scope. The defense and national security domain raises ethics, classification, and dual-use considerations; this domain is deferred from the pilot year pending development of appropriate ethics review procedures and is listed for community awareness only.

The constitution of specific domain groups will be finalized at the November 2026 Symposium based on attendance and demonstrated community interest. The Field Working Group will be constituted if it meets the formation floor and the Field participation condition. Every non-deferred candidate domain that independently meets the formation floor and the domain participation conditions is constituted. Domains that remain below those conditions stay on the suggestion list and may form later when they meet them.

A domain is constituted when at least five individuals have committed (proposed in the draft charter in Appendix A, subject to change), in writing before, at, or after the Symposium, to the year-one product, and those commitments include the domain participation conditions.⁶⁹ Among the five, at least one must be an active-inference expert and at least one must be a domain practitioner who is actively working in the domain. An individual who is both an active-inference expert and actively working in the domain may satisfy both role requirements and counts as one of the five. An active-inference expert whose work sits outside the domain fills the expert seat only. If a candidate domain has five written commitments but no active-inference expert, an SAB member or other active-inference expert may volunteer to join as a regular member to supply that role. SAB members join that role by volunteering. Interest below the floor, or a candidate that meets the numeric floor but misses the participation conditions, leaves the domain on the suggestion list. The continuation floor remains five active members under Article III.3. The formation floor of five is the number proposed to the Symposium. The ecosystem working group participants at Symposium may amend the provisional Charter, including the floor. After constitution, the floor may be changed only under Article X. Dual literacy in a single individual, where it exists, may be noted in the go/no-go. The formation floor still applies.

Healthcare and clinical medicine is listed because it is a high-value candidate if dual-literacy interest appears. This paper offers no claim that active inference is ready for incorporation into clinical procedures, devices, electronic health records, or pharmacology. Promotional claims of lives or dollars saved are outside the year-one warrant.⁷⁰

Year One Goals

Year-one goals differ for the Field group and for domain groups.

⁶⁹ Five committed members is the formation floor proposed to the Symposium because it matches the continuation floor already in Article III.3. The number is a proposal. The Symposium may amend it in the provisional Charter. After constitution, the floor may be changed only under Article X. The Field Working Group also requires that at least one of the five maintain or actively use an implementation in the initial comparison set. Domain groups also require an expert-practitioner complement among the five. Those are product-fit conditions. Any number of domains may form if they meet the floor and those conditions. Domains that miss the floor or the product-fit conditions remain on the suggestion list and may form later when they meet them.

⁷⁰ High-value domains are listed because the Institute judges the potential benefit to be large if translation succeeds. Potential benefit and present readiness are separate facts. This paper offers no clinical-outcome or health-system cost evidence for active-inference deployment in medicine.

Field Working Group. (1) Terminology correspondence matrix (e.g. in connection with the [Active Inference Ontology](#)). (2) Public comparison protocol, including at least one worked example across two implementations. (3) Shared domain-assessment framework, reviewed and agreed with constituted domain groups. The Field group holds the pen; domain groups participate so that the people who will use the rubric have a hand in writing it. (4) External review of the terminology matrix and the comparison protocol by at least two reviewers who are not AII Board members and who were not drafters. The Field Working Group may comment on the observations in Section 2. Any such comment is advisory.

The recommended sequence inside year one is a joint framework series in the first four months, with constituted domain groups participating, followed by domain self-assessments against the adopted framework. If the series runs long, a domain may produce a dated provisional self-assessment against the Symposium text of Section 7 and revise it after adoption.

Domain working groups. (1) Audience and use-case note: who the literacy product is for, and what domain problem it uses as context. (2) One literacy or adaptation module, short enough to be taught or circulated in a single sitting, designed jointly by at least one active-inference expert and at least one domain practitioner. (3) Participation in the Field group's framework series, and an initial domain assessment against the agreed framework. (4) A published go/no-go on the group's continuation, including a count of committed members, a statement that the expert–practitioner complement remains present, any dual-literacy individuals among the members, and a recommendation to continue, pause, or self-dissolve.

Those named products are the formation mandate. A group may add further work of the same type in its Year One Work Plan—another implementation in the comparison set, a second worked example, or a second literacy module for the same audience—if the addition does not displace the named products. A new class of work, a second domain, a certificate, tool ownership, or a standard requires rechartering. Subsequent years are a new decision.

Active members are expected to attend four quarterly meetings of approximately ninety minutes each and to contribute to at least one year-one product. Chair and Vice Chair roles carry additional coordination time. All meetings are conducted remotely. Membership requires no financial contribution.

Year Two and Later Work

The following are proposed as later work. The paper recommends them. Each group decides whether to take them up.

- Domain roadmaps, beginning from the year-one assessment, for groups that completed that assessment.
- Review of educational materials submitted by AII, universities, and other developers, for fit with the domain's readiness and use cases. Review is advisory. Members recuse when the materials come from their own organization. Certificate-program design, if pursued, belongs with education work and the SAB, with domain groups as optional reviewers.
- Skills, knowledge, and tools inventories that build on the assessment.
- Standards drafting, when a domain has the practitioner base described in Stage 6.

- Software-tool ownership. Tool development belongs with implementers. The Field Working Group may specify comparison needs.

Collapsing education ownership, tools ownership, and standards into the same quarterly domain group duplicates governance.⁷¹ Review and advice on materials, and a domain roadmap after assessment, are lighter and fit the form.

9. THE NOVEMBER 2026 SYMPOSIUM: CHARTER DEVELOPMENT SESSION

The Sixth Annual Applied Active Inference Symposium in November 2026 will include a Charter Development Session open to all attendees. The session launches a two-phase founding process designed to establish group operations while preserving time for community refinement of governance documents. The symposium is complementary Institute infrastructure. Working groups meet there. They do not convene it.

Phase 1: Symposium (November 2026)

Phase 1 has five objectives.

First, it will adopt the Working Groups Charter and Operating Procedures on a provisional basis, effective for a 90-day ratification period.

Second, it will constitute the Field Working Group, if it meets the formation floor and the Field participation condition, and every non-deferred candidate domain that independently meets the formation floor and the domain participation conditions, selected from the candidate list in Section 8 or from domains represented by Symposium attendees. How many domains will meet those conditions, and which domains will meet them, remains open until the Symposium.

Third, it will elect interim Chairs and Vice Chairs for each constituted group. A group that cannot elect those officers remains constituted but inactive until they are elected, and is paused if the vacancies persist for ninety days. Willing officers are welcome. They are a condition of activity. Constitution depends on the formation floor and the product-fit conditions.

Fourth, it will establish a 90-day calendar for Phase 2.

Fifth, it will consider, modify if needed, and adopt the seven-stage framework provisionally as the starting text for the year-one framework series. Participants may propose refinements.

Phase 2: Within 90 Days of the Symposium

Phase 2 has four objectives.

First, it will ratify the final Working Groups Charter and Operating Procedures. The final documents require a two-thirds supermajority of the combined active membership of all constituted groups. Ratification voting follows a one-person-one-vote standard. Eligibility is limited to members who joined a working group at least thirty days before the ratification vote date. During the provisional

⁷¹ Certificate design, tool ownership, and standards drafting are later or other Institute functions. They inform hosting and scope. They are outside year-one authorized outputs.

period, "active" membership is defined as attendance at one working-group meeting or documented asynchronous work on a deliverable activity. Members who cannot participate in real time may cast a direct written or authenticated electronic ballot submitted to the Chair at least forty-eight hours before the vote. Shared-process rules in the Field charter are amended the same way: supermajority of combined active membership, with AII Board concurrence under Article X. They are not amended by a majority of Symposium attendees.

Second, it will confirm the provisional framework as the starting text for the Field group's year-one series, or adopt a revised starting text.

Third, each group will finalize its Year One Work Plan, including the named products in Section 8, any same-type additions that do not displace those products, timeline, and member assignments.

Fourth, interim Chairs and Vice Chairs will stand for election under the ratified Charter.

Draft Charter and Operating Procedures are included as appendices. These drafts draw on IEEE Technical Committees, the W3C Working Group process, and the IETF's consensus-based standards process. They are a starting point for community review.

The Charter Development Session is open to all Symposium attendees. Participation imposes no obligation to join a working group. The session's goal is governance documents the community considers legitimate, including from participants who have reservations about the structure as proposed.

10. RISKS, SAFEGUARDS, AND GOVERNANCE PROTECTIONS

Any structured governance initiative carries risks. Identifying them openly is part of responsible design.

Risk: Continuation without Named Products

A group whose first job is to determine whether it should continue cannot produce an independent answer.

Safeguards: Section 2 is orientation. Year-one products are named in advance. Continuation requires those products plus, for the Field Working Group, external review. Confirmation of Section 2 cannot be the sole continuation test. Article XII states the stop rule.

Risk: Using Field Evidence to Constitute a Domain Group

Independent implementations and a missing comparison protocol are conditions for the Field Working Group. Each domain stands on its own interest and its own complement.

Safeguards: The paper and the Charter treat Field evidence as a Field warrant. Each domain group must meet the formation floor and the domain participation conditions on its own. Domain participation in the framework series is collaboration on method.

Risk: Premature Specification

Anticipatory coordination can prevent later incompatibility. It can also lock in an inferior convention or delay a better one.^{72, 73, 74}

Safeguards: The Field Working Group produces a protocol, a terminology correspondence matrix, and an assessment framework. Domain groups produce literacy products and an initial assessment. Domain roadmapping is proposed for year two, after the assessment. Standards language stays out of year-one authorized outputs.

Risk: Capture by a Single Perspective or Interest Group

A working group dominated by one research tradition, institution, or application community may produce outputs that reflect those participants rather than the field's state.

Safeguards: Open membership (Article III). Conflict of interest disclosure and recusal (Article IX), including recusal when a group reviews materials from a member's organization. Non-voting AII Liaison. Consensus-seeking model and formal objection (Article VI). Donation is not a condition of speaking.

Risk: Low Participation or Inactive Working Groups

A group that fails to maintain sufficient active membership cannot fulfill its mandate.

Safeguards: Formation floor of five committed members before constitution. Continuation floor of five active members (Article III.3). After notice, AII may suspend facilitation and publication (Article XI.4). AII may not dissolve a working group. A group may dissolve itself.

Risk: Scope Inflation and Output Quality

Groups may expand their scope beyond what they can credibly address, or produce outputs that overstate the field's state of development.

Safeguards: Named year-one products. Same-type additions may appear in the work plan; a new class of work requires rechartering (or a charter amendment). AII publication review limited to institutional scope. All outputs advisory and preliminary.

Risk: Process Legitimacy Concerns

If the community does not perceive the process as legitimate, the outputs will not carry authority.

Safeguards: Two-phase Symposium structure. Pre-Symposium public circulation through GitHub and the AII website. Formal objection and minority report provisions.

Risk: Outputs That Miscalibrate Field Expectations

Optimistic roadmaps or literacy materials that understate barriers could reproduce the expectation-reality gaps in Table 2.

⁷² Joseph Farrell and Garth Saloner, "Standardization, Compatibility, and Innovation."

⁷³ Paul A. David and Shane Greenstein, "The Economics of Compatibility Standards."

⁷⁴ Joseph Farrell and Timothy Simcoe, "Choosing the Rules for Consensus Standardization."

Safeguards: Domain roadmaps wait on a completed assessment. The seven-stage framework, if used, encourages honest stage assessment. SAB review can flag outputs inconsistent with the literature.

11. CALL TO ACTION

The November 2026 Symposium is the founding moment for this working-group system. The governance decisions made there will shape whether this work is worth continuing. The quality of those decisions depends on the range and depth of participation in making them.

AII is proposing this framework. The Charter, the Operating Procedures, the seven-stage heuristic, and the candidate domain list are starting drafts. Alternatives, objections, and better approaches are welcome. A bounded benchmark project without a standing group, a single Field Working Group with no domain groups, or a decision to wait are all admissible outcomes of the session.

Attending the Charter Development Session requires no prior commitment to a working group. Implementers and users of SPM, pymdp, RxInfer.jl, or another implementation are invited to the Field Working Group. Domain practitioners who want to help design a first literacy product and an initial domain assessment are invited to a domain group if that domain meets the formation floor and the domain participation conditions.

Concerns, objections, and alternative proposals belong at the Charter Development Session. Sustainable governance requires that disagreements be worked through in the open, at founding.

The work described here cannot be done by the Active Inference Institute alone. It requires implementers for the Field Working Group and domain practitioners for domain groups. The November 2026 Symposium is where the community decides whether those people are in the room.

How to Participate

AII has established dedicated platforms for community engagement in advance of the November 2026 Symposium.

The Charter Development Session at the Sixth Annual Applied Active Inference Symposium will be held in November 2026. Attendance is open to all registered Symposium participants. Remote participation options will be provided. All substantive votes will be accessible to remote participants. Registration information is available at activeinference.institute.

Review and comment on GitHub. The draft Working Group Charter and Operating Procedures (Appendices A and B) are available as living documents in AII's public GitHub repository at github.com/ActiveInferenceInstitute/Working_Groups . Readers may submit proposed changes by opening a GitHub Issue.

Comment through the AII website. Proposed changes and comments may be submitted through the AII Working Groups page at <https://activeinference.institute/working-groups/> .

Acknowledgments

The authors thank the members of the Active Inference Institute Scientific Advisory Board and Board of Directors who commented on earlier drafts. The structure described here also benefited from conversations at the 2024 and 2025 Applied Active Inference Symposia. The authors are grateful to the AII community volunteers whose years of work building coordination infrastructure make this proposal possible. Responsibility for the paper's arguments and for any errors of fact or judgment remains with the authors.

A bibliography and appendices follow below.

Appendix A is the draft charter

Appendix B is the draft operating procedures

Appendix C is Predecessor Governance Documents and Resources

Please note that the GitHub and Web pages on the Working Groups carry the living versions of Appendices A and B and may be updated after publication of this paper.

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APPENDIX A: WORKING GROUP CHARTER V1.0.0

Active Inference Institute | For Community Review and Adoption at the November 2026 Symposium

For updated version of the Working Group Charter see https://github.com/ActiveInferenceInstitute/Working_Groups/blob/main/docs/working_group_charter.md

Predecessor sources. This Charter draws on governance models of IEEE Technical Committees, the IETF Working Group process (RFC 2418), the W3C Process Document, the IRS Form 1023 sample conflict-of-interest policy, and the ANSI Essential Requirements. Per-provision sources and, where no predecessor applies, the design rationale appear in the footnotes to this appendix. A bibliography of predecessor documents appears in Appendix C.⁷⁵

ARTICLE I: NAME AND AFFILIATION

Section 1.1. Name. These working groups operate under the name "Active Inference Institute Working Groups" (collectively, the "AII Working Groups" or "Working Groups").⁷⁶

Section 1.2. Convener. The Active Inference Institute, a 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization, is the convening and publishing organization for the Working Groups. Working Groups are member-constituted bodies under this Charter. While AII serves as convener, Working Groups operate in accordance with this Charter, any supplementary Operating Procedures adopted pursuant to Article X, and AII institutional policies applicable to AII-published outputs. Withdrawal of AII as convener does not dissolve a Working Group. The AII Board may not dissolve a Working Group.⁷⁷

ARTICLE II: PURPOSE

Section 2.1. Purpose. The purpose of the Working Groups is to operate a Field Working Group and domain working groups. The Active Inference Field Working Group maintains a terminology correspondence note, a public comparison protocol for independently authored implementations, and a shared domain-assessment framework agreed with constituted domain groups. Domain working groups produce literacy and adaptation materials, an initial domain assessment against that framework, and a published go/no-go on the group's continuation. The number of domain groups constituted at founding is the number of non-deferred candidate domains that meet the formation floor and the domain participation conditions in Article III.4. Confirmation of the observations in Section 2 of the accompanying Position Paper is outside the authorized purpose of the Working Groups and is not a continuation warrant.⁷⁸

⁷⁵ IEEE TAB Operations Manual (Feb. 2023), opening statement and §§1–4; IETF RFC 2418; W3C Process Document (3 Nov. 2023); IRS Form 1023 sample conflict-of-interest policy (FREDLA reproduction of Appendix A); ANSI Essential Requirements (2010 NIST copy), §1.1 and §2.7. The prior ISACA COBIT attribution is withdrawn: the COBIT landing page has no operative disclosure or recusal text. This sentence identifies the predecessor set; per-provision pinpoints follow.

⁷⁶ RFC 2418 §2.2 requires a reasonably descriptive working-group name and a short identifier. The provision supplies that name for AII. No predecessor requires the specific collective title used here.

⁷⁷ RFC 2418 §2.2 affiliates a group with an Area and Area Director; W3C §3.4.1 places groups under a Team-appointed Chair and Team Contact; IEEE Societies operate inside IEEE (TAB §4.2). AII as 501(c)(3) convener and publisher is the local analog. The inversion—withdrawal of AII does not dissolve a group, and the Board may not dissolve a group—is proposal-specific. It reverses RFC 2418 §4 (the Area Director may disband) and W3C §4.6 (the Team may propose closure).

⁷⁸ RFC 2418 §2 and §2.2 treat the charter as a contract to produce specified products; W3C §4.2 requires mission, scope, deliverables, and success criteria. The named Field and domain products, and the rule that confirming the Position Paper's Section 2 observations is outside purpose, are facts of this proposal.

Section 2.2. Year-one outputs. Authorized year-one outputs differ for the Field Working Group and for domain groups. The Field Working Group is authorized to produce: (a) a terminology correspondence note; (b) a public comparison protocol, including at least one worked example; (c) a shared domain-assessment framework, reviewed and agreed with constituted domain groups; and (d) an external-review record for (a) and (b). The Field Working Group may add independently authored implementations to the comparison set in its Year One Work Plan without a Charter amendment. Each domain working group is authorized to produce: (a) an audience and use-case note; (b) one literacy or adaptation module; (c) participation in the Field Working Group's framework series and an initial domain assessment against the agreed framework; and (d) a published go/no-go on the group's continuation. A Working Group may add further work of the same type in its Year One Work Plan if the addition does not displace the named products. Changing the named year-one object, adding a new class of work, adding a second domain, or undertaking a certificate, tool-ownership, or standards product requires rechartering. A domain roadmap is authorized as subsequent-year work for a domain working group that has completed its initial assessment; it requires a new annual Work Plan decision. Subsequent years are a new decision.⁷⁹

Section 2.3. Publication and access. The Active Inference Institute is the exclusive official publisher of Working Group outputs produced under its institutional imprint. Official outputs are provided free of charge to all Working Group participants. Individual authors may publish their own independent papers, including papers that cite or build upon published Working Group outputs, in any venue. Unless the AII Board of Directors, upon recommendation of the relevant Working Group and with documented justification, authorizes a different access term for a specific output, official outputs are released to the public under Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International (CC BY 4.0). The terminology correspondence matrix, the comparison protocol, and the assessment framework shall remain publicly available at no charge. The Board may authorize a nominal charge to non-participants for other official outputs.⁸⁰

Section 2.4. Categories of authority. Authority within the Working Group system operates in three categories. Administrative authority—including budget allocation, institutional policies, IP policy, decisions to withdraw AII as convener, and AII institutional representations—rests with the AII Board of Directors. Substantive responsibility—including responsibility for technical analysis, domain assessments, interpretation of evidence, and conclusions contained in Working Group deliverables—rests with the Working Group members operating through the consensus process established in this Charter. Consensus under this Charter determines whether a text may be published as a Working Group position. It does not establish scientific consensus in the Active Inference field or independent scientific validation. Shared or appealable authority—including publication decisions, Charter amendments, and the interpretation of Charter provisions in specific cases—requires both Working Group action and AII Board concurrence as specified in the relevant articles of this Charter. Working Group members who believe the AII Board has exercised administrative authority in a manner that interferes with Working Group substantive responsibility may appeal in writing to the AII

⁷⁹ RFC 2418 §2.2 requires dated, demonstrable milestones; §5 requires rechartering for work beyond milestone revision. W3C §4.2 requires deliverables and the process for releasing them. The Field/domain product lists, the same-type addition rule, and the certificate / tool-ownership / standards / second-domain rechartering triggers are proposal-specific.

⁸⁰ W3C §7.1: technical reports are free to the public. TAB §4.2.B.7: Society publications require prior TAB authorization. RFC 5378 §§3.6, 5.9: the IETF Trust owns copyright in the published RFC as a collective work. Exclusive AII imprint, default CC BY 4.0, the no-charge lock on the three Field method products, and a possible nominal charge to non-participants for other outputs are proposal-specific.

Board; the Board shall respond in writing within thirty days. Where the dispute involves a claim that AII administrative action has materially compromised Working Group substantive independence, the appealing Working Group members may request independent review by a three-person panel composed of: one member selected by the Working Group, one member selected by the AII Board, and one member agreed upon by both parties within fifteen days. The panel's findings are advisory to the AII Board but shall be published alongside the Board's response in AII's public records.⁸¹

Section 2.5. Independent continuation tests. Evidence that supports the Field Working Group—including the existence of independently authored implementations and the absence of a public comparison protocol—shall not be treated as a warrant for constituting or continuing a domain working group. Domain participation in the assessment-framework series is collaboration on method and is likewise not a continuation warrant for the Field group or for any domain group. Each domain group must meet the formation floor and the domain participation conditions in Article III.4 on its own.⁸²

ARTICLE III: MEMBERSHIP

Section 3.1. Open membership. Working Group membership is open to any individual with relevant expertise or substantive interest who agrees to abide by this Charter, the Working Group Operating Procedures, and AII's Conflict of Interest Policy. Membership is open to critics of active inference and to domain practitioners who are not proponents of the framework.⁸³

Section 3.2. Institute membership not required. Membership in a Working Group does not require membership in the Active Inference Institute, though AII community membership is encouraged. Membership confers no financial compensation from AII unless separately authorized by the AII Board.⁸⁴

Section 3.3. Minimum active membership. Each Working Group shall maintain a minimum of five active members to remain in operation. A member is "active" if they have attended at least one meeting and contributed to at least one deliverable activity in the preceding six months.⁸⁵

Section 3.4. Formation Floor and Product-Fit Participation. A Working Group shall not be constituted at the founding Symposium, or thereafter, unless at least five individuals have committed in writing to the group's year-one product and the applicable participation conditions in this section

⁸¹ RFC 2418 §6.1 separates Chair process authority from document content (the Editor records group decisions). W3C §3.4.1 separates Chair coordination from the Team Contact. The three-category split (administrative / substantive / shared), the 30-day written Board response, and the three-person advisory panel are proposal-specific. They keep AII from becoming a scientific court. Consensus as an internal adoption rule, not field-wide scientific consensus, is likewise proposal-specific.

⁸² No predecessor states this rule. It is included so Field evidence (implementations exist; no comparison protocol exists) cannot be treated as a warrant to constitute or continue a domain group, and so shared method work is not a continuation warrant.

⁸³ RFC 2418 §1: participation is open to all; contributors act as individuals. ANSI Essential Requirements (2010) §1.1: participation shall be open to all persons directly and materially affected. Agreement to the Charter, Operating Procedures, and conflict-of-interest policy is the local condition of entry. The critics-and-non-proponents sentence is proposal-specific; none of the named predecessors states it.

⁸⁴ ANSI ER §1.1: voting membership shall not be conditional upon membership in any organization. TAB §4.2.A.2 is the opposite pattern (Society membership on payment of dues) and is not followed. Uncompensated service unless the Board separately authorizes payment is a 501(c)(3) control, not a predecessor rule.

⁸⁵ RFC 2418 §2.1 typically expects four or five active management participants plus a larger meeting and list cohort. Five is taken as the constitution and continuance floor, not as IETF's larger attendance expectation. The six-month activity test (one meeting and one deliverable contribution) is proposal-specific. RFC 2418 has no formal membership roster.

are met. Five is the number proposed to the Symposium. The Symposium may amend this number in the provisional Charter. After constitution, this number may be changed only under Article X.⁸⁶

(a) Field Working Group. The five written commitments must include at least one individual who maintains or actively uses an implementation included in the initial comparison set. Representation from every named implementation is not required at founding.⁸⁷

(b) Domain working groups. The five written commitments must include at least one active-inference expert and at least one domain practitioner who is actively working in the domain. An individual who is both an active-inference expert and actively working in the domain may satisfy both role requirements and counts as one of the five. An active-inference expert who is not actively working in the domain does not count as the domain practitioner. If a candidate domain has five written commitments but no active-inference expert, an SAB member or other active-inference expert may volunteer to join as a regular member under Section 3.1 to supply that role. SAB members join that role by volunteering. They are not assigned.⁸⁸

(c) Suggestion list. Interest below the floor, or a candidate that meets the numeric floor but not the product-fit conditions, leaves the domain on the suggestion list. Every non-deferred candidate domain that independently meets the floor and the domain conditions shall be constituted. Domains that do not meet those conditions at founding remain on the suggestion list and may form later when they meet them.⁸⁹

Section 3.5. Multiple-group participation. Members may participate in more than one Working Group. An individual serving in a leadership role (Chair or Vice Chair) in one Working Group may not simultaneously hold a leadership role in a second Working Group without approval from the AII Liaison.⁹⁰

Section 3.6. SAB participation. SAB members of the Active Inference Institute may participate in Working Groups in an advisory capacity. SAB participation does not carry voting authority on governance or budget matters, consistent with SAB members' advisory role under AII's governing documents. SAB members who separately join a Working Group as regular members under Section 3.1 participate in that capacity and may vote.⁹¹

⁸⁶ RFC 2418 §2.1: interest must be broad enough that the group is not a single-vendor activity. W3C §3.4.1: every group must have a charter before it operates. Written commitments to a named year-one product, Symposium authority to amend the number, and Article X for later changes are proposal-specific.

⁸⁷ No predecessor requires an implementer seat. The clause exists because the Field year's comparison protocol cannot be produced, as this proposal defines that product, without at least one person who maintains or uses an implementation in the initial set. Representation from every named implementation is deliberately not required.

⁸⁸ No predecessor states an expert–practitioner complement. The clause exists because the domain year-one products require both active-inference competence and current domain practice, and because dual literacy in one person is scarce. SAB members may volunteer into the expert seat; they are not assigned. That volunteer rule is proposal-specific.

⁸⁹ No predecessor uses a suggestion list. The clause exists so a domain that fails the floor or the product-fit conditions is not constituted, and so every non-deferred candidate that independently meets both conditions is constituted. There is no discretionary pick among qualified domains.

⁹⁰ TAB §2.2: no TAB member may hold more than one TAB voting position simultaneously. TAB §8.2.B: a candidate for a Committee Chair position shall not hold a similar responsibility in a subordinate organizational unit. Dual ordinary membership is allowed because the Field and domain products interact. Dual Chair/Vice Chair service needs Liaison approval so one person cannot capture two groups' process roles.

⁹¹ No predecessor defines an Institute scientific advisory board inside a working group. The clause exists because AII's SAB is advisory under AII governing documents. Advisory SAB participation therefore carries no governance or budget vote. A SAB

Section 3.7. Termination. Membership may be terminated by a two-thirds vote of the Working Group for conduct inconsistent with this Charter, the Operating Procedures, or AII's policies. The affected member shall be notified in writing and given an opportunity to respond before any vote is taken.⁹²

ARTICLE IV: OFFICERS

Section 4.1. Officers. Each Working Group shall elect a Chair and a Vice Chair from among its active members. Elections are held at or before the first regular meeting of each calendar year. Officers serve one-year terms and may be re-elected for up to two consecutive terms in the same role, after which they must stand down for at least one term before becoming eligible again.⁹³

Section 4.1(a). Vacancy and inactivity. If a constituted Working Group has not elected a Chair and a Vice Chair at or before its first regular meeting, it remains constituted but is inactive until those officers are elected. If the vacancies persist for ninety days after constitution, the group is paused. Willing officers are a condition of activity.⁹⁴

Section 4.2. Chair. The Chair is responsible for convening meetings, setting agendas in consultation with the Working Group, facilitating deliberations, ensuring that action items and decisions are recorded, and reporting to AII as specified in Article VII.⁹⁵

Section 4.3. Vice Chair. The Vice Chair assists the Chair and assumes the Chair's responsibilities in the Chair's absence. The Vice Chair leads at least one substantive workstream each year.⁹⁶

Section 4.4. AII Liaison. The AII Board of Directors shall designate an AII Liaison to the Working Groups. The AII Liaison is not a voting member of any Working Group but attends meetings, provides institutional guidance, and serves as the primary point of coordination between the Working Groups and the AII Board.⁹⁷

Section 4.5. Founding Period Continuity. From the Working Groups' initial constitution through December 31, 2029 (the Founding Period), the AII Board of Directors may authorize an

member who separately joins under §3.1 votes as a regular member. W3C Invited Experts are not a close analog and are not relied on.

⁹² TAB §3.2: a committee member may be removed, with or without cause, by two-thirds of the appointing body present, provided a quorum is present. This Charter requires cause (conduct inconsistent with the Charter, Operating Procedures, or AII policies), written notice, and an opportunity to respond before the vote. Those due-process elements are proposal-specific.

⁹³ TAB specifies officers and terms (for example, TAB Treasurer, two years, reappointment up to six years, §2.2 / §2.7.E). W3C §3.4.1: the Team appoints and reappoints Chairs—the opposite of election. RFC 2418 §6: Chairs serve at the Area Director's discretion; vice-chair election, fixed terms, and term limits are absent. Election from active members, a Vice Chair, a one-year term, and a two-consecutive-term limit are proposal-specific.

⁹⁴ No predecessor states this pause rule. It exists so a group can be constituted at the Symposium without officers, while making willing officers a condition of activity. Ninety days without a Chair and Vice Chair pauses the group; it does not dissolve it.

⁹⁵ RFC 2418 §6.1: the Chair is responsible for fair and open process, agendas, and progress, not for document content. TAB §2.7.A: the TAB Chair presides and makes specified appointments. Reporting to AII under Article VII is the local substitute for the RFC 2418 §6.1 after-session report to the Area Director.

⁹⁶ TAB §2.7.B: the Vice Chair assists the Chair and presides in the Chair's absence. RFC 2418 has no Vice Chair office. The requirement that the Vice Chair lead at least one substantive workstream is proposal-specific, so the office is not only a substitute gavel.

⁹⁷ W3C §3.4.1: each group must have a Team Contact as the interface among Chair, participants, and the Team; the Chair and Team Contact should not be the same individual. The AII Liaison is that interface. Non-voting status is proposal-specific, so the convener cannot vote the group's substance.

extension of a Chair's or Vice Chair's consecutive-term limits under Section 4.1, upon recommendation of the relevant Working Group and concurrence of the AII Liaison. Any extension under this provision shall be documented with the Board's stated justification and shall not extend service in the same role beyond the end of the Founding Period without a further Board action. This provision expires automatically on December 31, 2029 unless the AII Board acts to extend it.⁹⁸

ARTICLE V: MEETINGS

Section 5.1. Meeting frequency. Each Working Group shall meet at minimum once per calendar quarter. Additional meetings may be called by the Chair or by petition of one-third of active members with five business days' notice. This one-third threshold governs the right to request a meeting; decisions at any meeting require a quorum and voting majority as specified in Sections 6.1 and 6.3.⁹⁹

Section 5.2. Remote participation. Meetings shall be conducted in a manner accessible to geographically distributed members. Remote participation options shall be provided for all meetings.¹⁰⁰

Section 5.3. Agenda and minutes. The Chair shall distribute a written agenda at least five business days before each scheduled meeting. Minutes shall be recorded, reviewed by the Chair, and distributed to all Working Group members within ten business days of each meeting.¹⁰¹

ARTICLE VI: QUORUM AND DECISION-MAKING

Section 6.1. Quorum. A quorum for the purpose of taking binding votes is a majority of active members, which may include members attending remotely.¹⁰²

Section 6.2. Routine decisions. Routine decisions—including approval of agendas, meeting minutes, work assignments, and draft deliverables for internal circulation—require a simple majority of members present when a quorum is established.¹⁰³

Section 6.3. Supermajority decisions. The following decisions require a two-thirds supermajority of active members present and voting, provided quorum is established: (a) adoption of

⁹⁸ No predecessor states a founding-period waiver of term limits. The clause exists because a new Institute-convened system may need officer continuity through 31 December 2029, with a documented Board justification and automatic expiry.

⁹⁹ TAB §2.3.A requires at least two TAB meetings a year; this Charter uses a quarterly minimum as a more frequent local choice. TAB §2.3.C allows special meetings by the Chair or 20 percent of voting members; this Charter uses one-third of active members. RFC 2418 specifies no meeting frequency. The last sentence, separating the petition threshold from quorum and majority, is proposal-specific to prevent a calling minority from deciding the meeting.

¹⁰⁰ TAB §2.3.E permits meetings other than in person if notice is given and all participants can hear one another and propose, object, and vote. RFC 2418 §3.1 contemplates interim, telephone, and video sessions. W3C §3.1.2 distinguishes face-to-face from distributed meetings. Required remote options for every meeting are the local application of those rules to a geographically distributed membership.

¹⁰¹ RFC 2418 §7.1: final agenda at least two weeks before the session; §3.1: minutes required for every session. W3C §3.1.2.1: agenda two weeks before a face-to-face meeting (24 hours if distributed); minutes two weeks after (48 hours if distributed). TAB §2.5.C: agenda ten calendar days before TAB; §2.5.D: minutes within 45 days. Five and ten business days are a tightened local choice, not a copy of any one predecessor.

¹⁰² TAB committee charters repeatedly state that a majority of voting members constitutes a quorum (for example, §§3.7.I.3, 3.8.I.2, 3.9.I.3). W3C §5.2.1 does not require a quorum unless a charter adds one. RFC 2418 has no quorum rule. Remote attendees count because §5.2 makes remote participation a standing option.

¹⁰³ TAB §1.7 uses a simple majority of votes cast to revise the TAB Operations Manual. This Charter confines simple majority to routine process acts (agenda, minutes, assignments, internal drafts) so that publication, removal, operating-procedure amendment, and dissolution cannot pass on a bare majority.

a final deliverable for publication; (b) amendment of Working Group Operating Procedures; (c) removal of a member; and (d) dissolution of the Working Group.¹⁰⁴

Section 6.4. Consensus-seeking. All Working Groups operate on a consensus-seeking model. Before any formal vote, the Chair shall make reasonable effort to identify and address concerns that prevent consensus. Where consensus is not achievable, dissenting views shall be documented in the official record.¹⁰⁵

Section 6.5. Consensus Defined. For purposes of this Charter, consensus exists when no active member sustains a formal objection after the Chair has made reasonable effort to address the underlying concern. The absence of a formal objection constitutes consensus; a procedural concern raised but subsequently withdrawn does not prevent a finding of consensus. Consensus is distinct from unanimity; a member may express preference for a different outcome while choosing not to sustain a formal objection. Consensus under this Charter is an internal adoption rule for attributing a position to the Working Group. It is not scientific consensus in the Active Inference field and does not establish the scientific validity of the position adopted.¹⁰⁶

Section 6.6. Formal Objection Process. Any active member may file a formal objection to a proposed action or deliverable by submitting a written statement to the Chair specifying: (a) the provision or proposed action objected to; (b) the member's substantive concern; and (c) the change that would resolve the objection. The Chair shall distribute the formal objection to all active members and shall attempt to resolve it within twenty business days. If the formal objection is not resolved, it shall be documented in the official record and, where applicable, in the published deliverable.¹⁰⁷

Section 6.7. Minority Report. When a Working Group adopts a final deliverable over a sustained formal objection, the member or members who sustained the objection may file a minority report. The minority report shall be a brief written statement of the dissenting view. Minority reports shall be included as a separately identified appendix to the published deliverable, clearly labeled as the view of dissenting members and not as a Working Group position.¹⁰⁸

Section 6.8. Abstentions and Recusals. An abstention is recorded when a member is present and chooses not to vote; abstentions count neither for nor against the motion. A recusal occurs when a

¹⁰⁴ ANSI ER (2010) §2.7 gives as an example of consensus a majority of the body casting a vote and two-thirds of those voting, not counting abstentions. TAB §3.2 uses two-thirds to remove a committee member. IEEE-SA Standards Board Operations Manual §5.4.3.5 uses 75 percent Approve, not two-thirds, and is not the source of this threshold. Applying two-thirds to final publication, operating-procedure amendment, removal, and dissolution is a local grouping of those acts.

¹⁰⁵ RFC 2418 §3 and §3.3: working groups decide by rough consensus; 51 percent does not qualify. W3C §5.2.1: Chairs must ensure that groups consider legitimate views and objections and endeavor to resolve them. ANSI ER Annex A: consensus is more than a simple majority but not necessarily unanimity, and all views and objections are to be considered. Documenting dissent in the official record is the local recording rule.

¹⁰⁶ W3C §5.2.1: the Chair makes the final determination of consensus. RFC 2418 §3.3: the Chair determines whether rough consensus exists; unanimity is preferred but not required. “No sustained formal objection after reasonable effort” is closer to W3C than to IETF humming. The last two sentences—consensus is an internal adoption rule, not scientific consensus in the field—are proposal-specific.

¹⁰⁷ W3C §5.5: a Formal Objection must include a summary of the issue, the decision appealed, and the rationale. This section requires the provision objected to, the substantive concern, and the change that would resolve it. The twenty-business-day resolution window and the requirement to record an unresolved objection in the published deliverable are proposal-specific. RFC 2418 has no formal-objection procedure.

¹⁰⁸ W3C §5.6.2.6 permits a Minority Opinion when a W3C Council decision is not unanimous. RFC 2418 has no minority-report rule. This section adapts the W3C device to an adopted Working Group deliverable, as a separately labeled appendix that is not a Working Group position.

member is required to remove themselves from a specific deliberation and vote due to a conflict of interest under Article IX; recusals reduce the quorum requirement proportionally—quorum is calculated based on active members eligible to vote on that specific matter.¹⁰⁹

Section 6.9. Asynchronous Voting. For routine decisions that do not require deliberation, the Chair may conduct an asynchronous vote by distributing the motion to all active members by email or equivalent documented channel. Asynchronous votes shall remain open for at least five business days. Votes not cast within the open period are treated as non-votes and do not count toward or against either quorum or the required majority. An asynchronous vote is binding only if at least a quorum of active members as defined in Section 6.1 cast votes within the open period. Asynchronous voting is not available for adoption of final deliverables, amendment of Operating Procedures, removal of members, or dissolution of the Working Group, which require deliberative votes at a meeting where quorum is established.¹¹⁰

ARTICLE VII: DELIVERABLES AND REPORTING

Section 7.1. Year One Work Plan. Each Working Group shall adopt a Year One Work Plan at or before its second regular meeting. The Work Plan shall specify the products authorized for that group in Article II.2, the timeline for each, and the member assignments responsible for each. The Work Plan may add further work of the same type if the addition does not displace the named products. Certificate design, tool ownership, and standards drafting require rechartering. A domain roadmap may be assigned only in a subsequent-year Work Plan, and only after the domain working group has completed its initial assessment.¹¹¹

Section 7.2. Quarterly reports. Working Group Chairs shall submit a brief written report to the AII Liaison no less than quarterly. The report shall cover: meetings held and attendance; progress on Year One deliverables; emerging issues or resource needs; and any matters requiring AII Board awareness or action.¹¹²

Section 7.3. Publication review. Final deliverables shall be submitted to the AII Liaison for review against AII's publication standards and IP Policy prior to publication. AII is the exclusive official publisher of those deliverables. AII reserves the right to request revisions for consistency with institutional policies, accuracy of institutional representations, or adherence to the access and licensing terms in Section 2.3. Responsibility for content, technical analysis, and conclusions remains

¹⁰⁹ ANSI ER §2.7 treats abstention as a recognized voting position and, in the example test, does not count abstentions toward the two-thirds. IRS sample conflict-of-interest policy, Art. III §§2–3: the interested person leaves the meeting for discussion and vote. Reducing quorum to members eligible on that matter is the local combination of those two rules. RFC 2418 and W3C Process do not define abstention or recusal math.

¹¹⁰ RFC 2418 §3.3 describes mailing-list consensus assessment (the Chair states the presumed consensus and asks for comment). ANSI ER §2.7 permits votes by letter, fax, recorded meeting vote, or electronic means. A five-business-day open period, non-votes counting toward neither side, a cast-vote quorum, and a ban on asynchronous votes for the §6.3 acts are proposal-specific.

¹¹¹ RFC 2418 §2.2: the charter is a contract to meet explicit milestones and deliver specified products. W3C §4.2 requires deliverables, milestone dates, and the approval process for release. Adoption at or before the second regular meeting, same-type additions that do not displace named products, and the ban on certificates, tool ownership, and standards without rechartering are proposal-specific.

¹¹² RFC 2418 §6.1: immediately after a session the Chair must send the Area Director a short report. TAB §4.4.6 requires provisional-society status reports to the Society and Council Review Committee. Quarterly reports to the AII Liaison, with the four specified contents, are the local reporting cadence.

with the Working Group. AII administrative review shall not substitute institutional judgment for Working Group scientific inquiry.¹¹³

Section 7.4. Output identification. Published Working Group outputs shall identify the Working Group by name, acknowledge AII as the convening organization, and carry a publication date and version number consistent with AII's document control conventions.¹¹⁴

Section 7.5. Official outputs. Official Working Group outputs are the AII-published reports, protocols, frameworks, and analogous deliverables adopted under this Charter. Journal articles and conference papers by individual contributors are not official Working Group outputs. They may follow ICMJE or comparable scholarly authorship standards.¹¹⁵ Official outputs shall attribute contributors through a Contributors section, with the Working Group identified as the producing body and AII identified as the publishing organization.¹¹⁶

Section 7.6. External Review. The Field Working Group's terminology correspondence matrix and comparison protocol shall be reviewed by at least two reviewers who are not AII Board members and who were not drafters. The assessment framework is adopted by Field Working Group concurrence with constituted domain groups under Article II.2. Domain go/no-go statements shall be published with the membership count, a statement that the expert–practitioner complement required in Article III.4(b) remains present, and any dual-literacy individuals among the members.¹¹⁷

ARTICLE VIII: INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY

Section 8.1. Contribution agreement. Intellectual property contributed to or created within the Working Group process is governed by AII's Intellectual Property Policy (AII-POL-IP-001). Members contributing original content to Working Group deliverables shall execute an IP Contribution Agreement in the form specified by that policy. Where a member's contributions are made in the course of their employment, the member represents that they have obtained any employer authorization required to contribute that content to the Working Group process under these terms, or that no such authorization is required. AII is not responsible for resolving disputes between members and their employers regarding the ownership of contributed content.¹¹⁸

¹¹³ W3C §6.2.1: the Team is not required to publish a Technical Report that does not conform to publication rules. TAB §4.2.B.7: Society publications other than programs and notices require prior TAB authorization. Exclusive official publication by AII follows §2.3. The last two sentences—content responsibility remains with the Working Group; administrative review shall not substitute institutional judgment for Working Group scientific inquiry—are proposal-specific.

¹¹⁴ W3C §6.2.1 publication rules cover naming, status information, and form. RFC 2418 §7.3 and §7.5 require identified, formatted documents in the Internet-Drafts directory. Naming the Working Group, acknowledging AII as convener, and carrying AII date and version conventions are the local identification rule.

¹¹⁵ International Committee of Medical Journal Editors, "Defining the Role of Authors and Contributors," Recommendations for the Conduct, Reporting, Editing, and Publication of Scholarly Work in Medical Journals, updated 2022, <https://www.icmje.org>.

¹¹⁶ ICMJE, "Defining the Role of Authors and Contributors," four-criteria authorship (already cited as note 75). ICMJE also recognizes group-name authorship. The split—ICMJE or comparable standards for journal and conference papers; a Contributors section for technical reports and policy briefs—is proposal-specific, because not every official output is a scholarly article.

¹¹⁷ RFC 2418 §8: IETF Last-Call is a brief final community check, not a substitute for in-depth review. W3C §6.2.2.1 requires wide review by stakeholders. Two reviewers who are not Board members and were not drafters, Field–domain concurrence for the assessment framework, and go/no-go publication of membership count and the expert–practitioner complement are proposal-specific.

¹¹⁸ RFC 5378 §5.1: a contributor is deemed to have obtained needed permissions from known rights holders, including a sponsor or employer. RFC 5378 §3.3: a working group may formally adopt a contribution only if the right to produce derivative works has been granted. W3C Community Contributor License Agreement §2.1 is a non-exclusive copyright grant;

Section 8.2. Authorship credit. Working Group members retain authorship credit for their contributions to published deliverables, consistent with the authorship standards the Working Group adopts in its Operating Procedures.¹¹⁹

Section 8.3. Exclusive official publisher. AII is the exclusive official publisher of Working Group outputs produced under its institutional imprint. Prior to AII publication, Working Group members and contributors may not publish the same substantive content elsewhere without written consent of the AII Board. "Same substantive content" means the Working Group's actual adopted deliverable text. It leaves untouched derivative works, applications of the Working Group's findings, and scholarly publications that cite or build upon Working Group outputs without reproducing the adopted text. After AII publication under the access and licensing terms in Section 2.3, third parties—including Working Group members and contributors—may use those outputs as that license or access term allows, provided attribution to AII and the relevant Working Group is maintained.¹²⁰

Section 8.4. Community resource. No Working Group member or contributor may claim proprietary rights over content developed within the Working Group process. Content developed through the Working Group process is a community resource: it may not be transferred to the exclusive ownership or control of any individual, institution, or organization outside the access and licensing terms in Section 2.3.¹²¹

Section 8.5. IP policy pending. AII's full Intellectual Property Policy (AII-POL-IP-001) is in development and will be adopted by the AII Board before the final Charter is ratified. AII-POL-IP-001 will be made publicly available before that ratification vote, and the IP Contribution Agreement referenced in Section 8.1 will be consistent with its terms. If any provision of the finally adopted AII-POL-IP-001 conflicts with this Charter, the IP Policy controls for IP matters and this Charter controls for governance matters. AII will provide written notice to Working Group members of the finally adopted AII-POL-IP-001 at least thirty days before the ratification vote.¹²²

ARTICLE IX: CONFLICT OF INTEREST

Section 9.1. Disclosure. Working Group members shall disclose to the Chair any financial, professional, or personal interest that could affect, or could reasonably appear to affect, their

this Charter does not adopt that CLA text. AII-POL-IP-001 and the named contribution agreement are still in development (§8.5). AII's refusal to referee member–employer ownership disputes is proposal-specific.

¹¹⁹ RFC 5378 §5.10: contributors retain the right to use their contributions as published, subject to not misrepresenting an incomplete copy as the official RFC. ICMJE four-criteria authorship governs credit in scholarly formats (§7.5). Retention of authorship credit, with the detailed standard left to the Operating Procedures, follows those two sources.

¹²⁰ RFC 5378 §§3.6, 5.9: the IETF Trust owns copyright in the RFC as a collective work and others may not republish or modify an RFC in RFC format; contributors keep underlying rights. Exclusive official publication before AII release is the local analog. The definition of "same substantive content" (adopted deliverable text only) and post-publication use under §2.3, including CC BY 4.0, are proposal-specific and more open than IETF Trust exclusive format.

¹²¹ RFC 5378 §2: copyright procedures are intended to benefit the community and the public while respecting legitimate rights. W3C CLA §2.1 is a non-exclusive grant, not an assignment of exclusive ownership to a participant. The ban on transferring process content to any individual's or institution's exclusive control, outside §2.3, is proposal-specific.

¹²² No predecessor leaves its IP policy unadopted at charter time. The clause exists because AII-POL-IP-001 is not yet Board-adopted. Members cannot be asked to ratify unknown terms. Thirty days' written notice, public availability before the ratification vote, and the IP-versus-governance conflict rule are the local controls.

objectivity in a Working Group decision or deliverable. Disclosure shall be made promptly upon the member becoming aware of the potential conflict.¹²³

Section 9.2. Recusal. A member with a disclosed conflict shall recuse themselves from the relevant deliberation and vote. The recusal and its basis shall be recorded in the meeting minutes.¹²⁴

Section 9.3. Undisclosed conflicts. Undisclosed conflicts that subsequently come to light shall be reviewed by the AII Liaison and the Chair jointly. If the review finds that a material conflict was not disclosed, the matter may be referred to the AII Board.¹²⁵

Section 9.4. Donations not a condition. Financial contribution to AII, including donation, is not a condition of membership, speaking, or participation.¹²⁶

ARTICLE X: AMENDMENT

Section 10.1. Charter amendment. This Charter may be amended by a two-thirds supermajority vote of the combined active membership of all constituted Working Groups, provided that the proposed amendment has been circulated to all Working Group members at least thirty days before the vote, and that the AII Board has reviewed and concurred with the proposed change.¹²⁷

Section 10.2. Operating Procedures. Supplementary Operating Procedures for each Working Group may be adopted and amended by a two-thirds supermajority of that Working Group's active members, with notification to the AII Liaison. Operating Procedures may not conflict with this Charter or with AII's governing documents.¹²⁸

Section 10.3. Domain Charter Template and Compatibility. Each domain Working Group operates under a charter derived from the Domain Working Group Charter Template. A domain Working Group may adopt supplementary provisions or modifications, provided they remain compatible with this Charter's open-membership, publication, shared-assessment-framework, and stop-rule provisions. Compatibility is determined by the Field Working Group as a process check. Compatibility review does not extend to scientific or technical judgments of the domain Working

¹²³ IRS Form 1023 sample conflict-of-interest policy (FREDLA reproduction), Art. III §1: an interested person must disclose the financial interest and all material facts. TAB §2.11.B and §8.2.B require conflict disclosure for TAB candidates and treat conflict as broader than monetary advantage; they are officer-and-candidate rules, not a working-group recusal code. COBIT is not used. Prompt disclosure to the Chair, covering financial, professional, or personal interests, is the local adaptation.

¹²⁴ IRS sample policy, Art. III §§2–3: after disclosure the interested person leaves the meeting for determination, discussion, and vote. Art. IV: minutes record the names, the nature of the interest, the determination, and the vote. Recusal from both deliberation and vote, with the basis recorded, follows that sample.

¹²⁵ IRS sample policy, Art. III §4: if a body has reasonable cause to believe a member failed to disclose, it informs the member, hears the response, investigates, and may take disciplinary or corrective action. Joint Liaison-and-Chair review, with Board referral for a material undisclosed conflict, is the local adaptation to a convener-plus-working-group structure.

¹²⁶ ANSI ER (2010) §1.1: there shall be no undue financial barriers to participation. The clause applies that rule to AII donations: money given to the Institute is not a condition of membership, speaking, or participation.

¹²⁷ TAB §1.7: proposed Operations Manual changes and reasons must be distributed at least ten days before the vote; a simple majority of votes cast approves; Governance Committee review and TAB approval follow. W3C §11: Process revision requires Advisory Committee review of at least 28 days. ANSI ER §2.7 supplies the two-thirds example. This Charter uses thirty days' circulation, two-thirds of combined active membership, and Board concurrence—stricter notice and a higher threshold than TAB §1.7.

¹²⁸ W3C §6.1: groups may adopt additional publication processes so long as they do not conflict with the Process Document. Two-thirds of that Working Group's active members, with Liaison notification, and a ban on conflict with this Charter or AII governing documents, are the local rule. TAB §1.7's simple majority is not used for Operating Procedures.

Group. Field products are adopted by the Field Working Group, with notice to constituted domain groups. Domain products are adopted by that domain Working Group.¹²⁹

ARTICLE XI: DISSOLUTION AND WITHDRAWAL OF THE CONVENER

Section 11.1. Dissolution. A Working Group may be dissolved only by a two-thirds supermajority vote of its active members. The AII Board may not dissolve a Working Group.¹³⁰

Section 11.2. Records on dissolution. Upon self-dissolution, if AII is then the convener, the Working Group's official records shall be transferred to AII for archiving, and any unpublished deliverables in progress shall be documented with their current status. If AII is not then the convener, the records remain with the Working Group unless its members transfer them.¹³¹

Section 11.3. Withdrawal of AII as Convener. AII may withdraw as convening and publishing organization by published Board action, with at least thirty days' written notice to all Working Group members. Withdrawal does not dissolve any Working Group. After withdrawal, a Working Group may continue independently, adopt another convening organization, or dissolve itself under Section 11.1. AII-published outputs already released remain AII publications. Subsequent outputs are not AII publications unless a later convening agreement so provides.¹³²

Section 11.4. Inactive Groups. If a Working Group fails to hold any meeting within any consecutive six-month period, or fails to submit required quarterly reports under Section 7.2 for two consecutive reporting periods, the AII Liaison shall provide written notice to the Working Group and a thirty-day period to remedy the deficiency. If the deficiency is not remedied within thirty days of notice, AII may suspend its facilitation and publication for that group. AII may not restructure the group's leadership or membership, and may not dissolve the group. The AII Board shall provide written notice of any such action to all Working Group members.¹³³

ARTICLE XII: PILOT EVALUATION, STOP RULE, AND SUNSET REVIEW

Section 12.1. Twelve-Month Pilot Evaluation. No later than twelve months after the initial constitution of the Working Groups at the November 2026 Symposium, the AII Board of Directors and the Chairs of all constituted Working Groups shall conduct a Pilot Evaluation of the Working Group system. The Pilot Evaluation shall assess: (a) whether each group produced the year-one products named for that group in Article II.2; (b) whether those products were used by at least one

¹²⁹ No predecessor uses a domain-charter template with a Field process-compatibility check. The clause exists so domain groups can add supplementary provisions without breaking open membership, publication, the shared assessment framework, or the stop rule, and so the Field group cannot use “compatibility” to reopen a domain’s scientific judgments.

¹³⁰ This provision inverts RFC 2418 §4 (the Area Director, consulting the group, may disband it) and W3C §4.6 (the Team, TAG, or Advisory Board may propose closure, confirmed by Advisory Committee Review). Two-thirds of the group's active members is the only dissolution path. The Board-may-not-dissolve sentence is the master limitation of this proposal.

¹³¹ No predecessor states a records-and-unpublished-work rule keyed to whether the convener is still in place. The clause exists so official records are archived if AII is then the convener, and so they remain with the group if AII has already withdrawn.

¹³² No predecessor provides for sponsor withdrawal that leaves the working group intact. IETF, W3C, and IEEE treat the host organization as constitutive. Thirty days' notice, continuation or self-dissolution after withdrawal, and the rule that already-published AII outputs remain AII publications are proposal-specific.

¹³³ TAB §4.9 requires periodic monitoring of Societies, Councils, and Technical Communities; §4.4.6 makes failure to meet provisional-society objectives a cause for dissolution or merger. RFC 2418 §4 allows a completed group to become dormant rather than disband. This Charter permits AII only to suspend facilitation and publication after notice and a thirty-day cure. AII may not restructure leadership or membership and may not dissolve the group.

intended external audience, or received the required external review; (c) whether working groups have achieved and maintained minimum activity standards under Article III; (d) whether the governance structure in the Charter and Operating Procedures is functioning as intended or requires amendment; and (e) whether the AII coordination infrastructure is adequately supporting working group operations. Completion of the assessment framework and of domain self-assessments is a year-one product test. Stage ratings under the framework are analytical results and are not themselves a continuation test.¹³⁴

Section 12.2. Stop Rule. Continuation of a Working Group, and constitution of any additional domain group, shall not rest solely on a confirmation of the observations in Section 2 of the Position Paper. A group that has not produced its named year-one products shall be paused. For the Field Working Group, the terminology matrix and the comparison protocol must also receive the external review required in Article VII.6. AII shall suspend facilitation and publication for a paused group unless the Working Group and the AII Board concur in a published, time-limited exception stating what product is still due and by when. AII may not dissolve the group. The Field Working Group may be rechartered only if the comparison protocol has been used by at least two implementation communities and has received the external review required in Article VII.6. A domain group may be rechartered only after a published go/no-go recommending continuation. A domain roadmap may be taken up only after that go/no-go and only as a subsequent-year Work Plan decision. Rechartering is a new decision. A change in the named object, or the addition of a new class of work other than a post-assessment domain roadmap, requires rechartering under Article II.¹³⁵

Section 12.3. Five-Year Sunset Review. No later than five years after the initial constitution of the Working Groups at the November 2026 Symposium, and every five years thereafter, the AII Board of Directors and the collective active membership of all then-constituted Working Groups shall conduct a comprehensive Sunset Review of the Working Group system.¹³⁶

Section 12.4. Sunset Review criteria. The five-year Sunset Review shall assess: (a) whether the Working Group system continues to serve its stated purposes and the active inference community's needs; (b) whether the Field charter and domain-charter template should be retained, narrowed, or expanded; (c) whether the governance structure, including this Charter, requires substantive revision; and (d) whether any Working Groups that remain constituted continue to fulfill their mandates productively.¹³⁷

Section 12.5. Public sunset report. The five-year Sunset Review shall produce a public report available to the active inference community within thirty days of completion. Recommended changes

¹³⁴ TAB §4.4.6 reviews a provisional society against its Full Proposal, normally at three years, with a five-year outer bound. W3C §4.2 typically charters a group for six months to two years. A twelve-month product-and-use evaluation, with stage ratings excluded from the continuation test, is proposal-specific.

¹³⁵ RFC 2418 §4: if a group cannot complete chartered work, the Area Director may recharter, replace chairs, or disband. TAB New Technical Communities have a five-year maximum lifetime (§4.8). Pause rather than dissolve, the ban on using Section 2 confirmation as a continuation warrant, the external-review and go/no-go gates, and rechartering as a new decision are proposal-specific.

¹³⁶ TAB §4.8: New Technical Communities have a five-year maximum after initial TAB funding. TAB §4.4.6 expects provisional-society objectives within five years. A recurring five-year Sunset Review by the Board and the collective active membership, rather than automatic expiry, is proposal-specific.

¹³⁷ TAB §4.9 monitors technical and financial success and provides for assessment review. The four Sunset criteria—continued purpose, Field and domain-template scope, governance revision, and remaining mandates—are the local review agenda.

to this Charter shall be proposed under the amendment process in Article X. The first five-year Sunset Review is due no later than November 2031.¹³⁸

APPENDIX B: OPERATING PROCEDURES V1.0.0

Active Inference Institute Working Groups | For Community Review and Adoption at the November 2026 Symposium

For updated version of Operating Procedures see https://github.com/ActiveInferenceInstitute/Working_Groups/blob/main/docs/operating_procedures.md

These Operating Procedures supplement the Working Group Charter (Appendix A). Where any provision of these Procedures conflicts with the Charter, the Charter controls. Individual Working Groups may adopt Working-Group-specific supplementary procedures, provided those procedures are consistent with both this document and the Charter, and are filed with the AII Liaison.¹³⁹

1. Meeting Conduct

1.1. The Chair opens each meeting by confirming quorum and reviewing the agenda. Agenda modifications require the consent of a simple majority of members present.¹⁴⁰

1.2. Members are expected to arrive prepared, having reviewed any pre-circulated materials. Discussion time at meetings is for deliberation, not for first reading of documents.¹⁴¹

1.3. The Chair facilitates discussion to ensure equitable participation. Any member may call a point of order if they believe the meeting is not being conducted in accordance with the Charter or these Procedures.¹⁴²

1.4. Meetings shall not exceed two hours without explicit consent of a majority of members present. Extended working sessions may be scheduled separately.¹⁴³

2. Agenda and Minutes

¹³⁸ No predecessor requires a public sunset report on a fixed date. The clause exists so the first review is due by November 2031, the report is public within thirty days, and Charter changes still go through Article X rather than through the review itself.

¹³⁹ W3C §6.1: a group may adopt additional processes if they do not conflict with the Process Document. Charter-controls, Liaison filing, and Working-Group-specific supplements are the local hierarchy. They implement Charter §10.2.

¹⁴⁰ Implements Charter §§6.1–6.2. TAB §2.5 distinguishes action items from information items and requires approval of minutes at the next meeting. Opening by confirming quorum is the local chairing rule; it is not copied from a predecessor sentence.

¹⁴¹ RFC 2418 §3.1: the agenda should indicate what documents participants must read to be prepared. RFC 2418 §3.2: the Chair may refuse the floor to a person who is unprepared. The “no first reading” sentence applies those rules to meeting time.

¹⁴² RFC 2418 §6.1: the Chair is responsible for a fair and open process. W3C §5.2.1: Chairs must ensure that legitimate views and objections are considered. A point of order is ordinary parliamentary practice; it is not taken from IEEE TAB, RFC 2418, or W3C Process.

¹⁴³ No predecessor caps meeting length. The two-hour default exists because the membership is geographically distributed and remote. A majority of those present may extend; longer work is scheduled separately so ordinary meetings stay usable.

2.1. The Chair circulates a draft agenda no later than five business days before each meeting, inviting additions from members.¹⁴⁴

2.2. The Chair designates a note-taker for each meeting. Minutes shall record: (a) date, time, and participants; (b) agenda items discussed; (c) decisions taken and vote counts for formal votes; (d) action items with assigned owners and due dates; and (e) any conflicts of interest disclosed and recusals taken. Minutes shall not be verbatim transcripts of deliberations.¹⁴⁵

2.3. Draft minutes are circulated to all Working Group members within ten business days of each meeting. Members have ten additional business days to submit written corrections. Corrected minutes are approved at the following meeting.¹⁴⁶

3. Deliverable Development Process

3.1. Each deliverable shall have a designated Lead Member responsible for coordinating its development, maintaining the working draft, and managing the review cycle. Deliverables shall match the products authorized for that Working Group in Charter Article II.2.¹⁴⁷

3.2. Working drafts are internal Working Group documents and shall be clearly marked as such. No working draft may be represented externally as a Working Group position or AII publication.¹⁴⁸

3.3. Before a deliverable proceeds to a final adoption vote, it shall undergo at least one structured internal review cycle in which all active members have the opportunity to submit written comments. The Lead Member shall prepare a written response to all substantive comments received.¹⁴⁹

3.4. The Chair may invite SAB members or external domain experts to review a deliverable before final adoption. External reviewers shall be disclosed in the published document's acknowledgments.¹⁵⁰

¹⁴⁴ Same lineage as Charter §5.3; RFC 2418 §7.1 (two weeks), W3C §3.1.2.1 (two weeks face-to-face; 24 hours distributed), TAB §2.5.C (ten calendar days). Five business days and an invitation for member additions are the local choice.

¹⁴⁵ RFC 2418 §3.1: minutes should include the agenda, an account of discussion and decisions, and attendees. TAB §2.5.D: minutes record attendance, the substance of discussions, and actions, and need not be a verbatim transcript. IRS sample policy Art. IV requires recording of conflicts and recusals. Items (a)–(e) combine those rules. The last sentence follows TAB's non-verbatim rule.

¹⁴⁶ TAB §2.5.D: minutes are distributed before the next regular meeting and approved there. W3C §3.1.2.1: minutes two weeks after a face-to-face meeting. Ten business days to circulate and ten to correct, with approval at the following meeting, are the local windows.

¹⁴⁷ RFC 2418 §6.3: a group designates an Editor; as a general practice the Chair and Document Editor are different people. W3C §6.2.1: each Technical Report is edited by one or more editors appointed by the Chair. "Lead Member" is that role. Matching Charter Article II.2 products implements the charter-as-contract rule.

¹⁴⁸ W3C §6.3.1: Editor's drafts have no official standing and do not imply Working Group or W3C endorsement; Working Drafts do not necessarily represent consensus. The marking and non-representation rule applies that distinction to AII working drafts.

¹⁴⁹ W3C §6.2.2: Working Groups should formally address substantive review comments in a timely manner. ANSI ER §§1.6, 2.6: prompt consideration of written views and objections, with written disposition and reasons. One structured internal cycle and a written response to every substantive comment are the local application.

¹⁵⁰ RFC 2418 §8 Last-Call and W3C §6.2.2.1 wide review are community-scale checks. This section makes SAB or external expert review optional with the Chair, and requires disclosure in acknowledgments. It does not replace Charter §7.6's mandatory Field external review.

3.5. After the Working Group adopts a final deliverable, the Chair submits it to the AII Liaison for institutional review per Article VII.3 of the Charter. The AII Liaison shall complete institutional review within twenty business days.¹⁵¹

4. Authorship and Attribution

4.1. Authorship of Working Group deliverables is determined by the Working Group using criteria consistent with recognized academic standards for scholarly authorship (ICMJE criteria: substantive intellectual contribution to conception or design, or to data acquisition, analysis, or interpretation; AND drafting or critical revision of the work; AND approval of the final version; AND accountability for the work). Members who contributed only through meeting participation, administrative support, or general direction shall be acknowledged but are not listed as authors.¹⁵²

4.2. Published deliverables shall identify the Working Group by name, list the authors in the order agreed by the Working Group, and acknowledge AII as the institutional publisher. The publication date, version number, and DOI (once assigned) shall appear on the document.¹⁵³

5. Communication and Transparency

5.1. Working Group business is conducted through channels designated by the Chair and accessible to all active members. Minutes, Work Plans, and adopted deliverables shall be filed with the AII Liaison and made available on AII's public platforms upon adoption.¹⁵⁴

5.2. Working Group members may communicate publicly about their personal expertise and about published Working Group outputs. Members shall not characterize Working Group positions or AII positions on matters that have not been formally adopted.¹⁵⁵

5.3. Media inquiries about Working Group activities shall be referred to the AII Liaison. Individual members may speak to the media in their personal capacity, provided they make clear that they do not speak for the Working Group or for AII.¹⁵⁶

6. Onboarding New Members

¹⁵¹ Implements Charter §7.3. W3C §6.2.1: the Team may refuse a nonconforming publication. The twenty-business-day Liaison clock is proposal-specific. IEEE-SA §5.1.2.1(p)(5)'s twenty-day access clock is a different obligation and is not the source.

¹⁵² ICMJE four criteria, quoted in the section: substantial contribution to conception, design, or data; drafting or critical revision; final approval; and accountability... (continued on next page) (<https://www.icmje.org/recommendations/browse/roles-and-responsibilities/defining-the-role-of-authors-and-contributors.html>). ICMJE: persons who provided only general supervision, administrative support, or meeting participation are acknowledged, not listed as authors. Already cited in the Charter as note 75.

¹⁵³ Implements Charter §7.4. W3C §6.2.1 publication rules require public, identifiable Technical Reports. Author order by Working Group agreement, AII as institutional publisher, and date, version, and DOI are the local identification block.

¹⁵⁴ RFC 2418 treats the mailing list as the standing venue and requires minutes to be posted. W3C §7.1: public communication; technical reports are public. TAB §2.5 requires distribution of minutes. Designated channels accessible to all active members, and public posting of minutes, Work Plans, and adopted deliverables, apply those rules to AII platforms.

¹⁵⁵ No predecessor states this speech rule in these terms. It exists so members can discuss their own expertise and published outputs without characterizing a Working Group or AII position that has not been adopted. It is the public-facing counterpart of Operating Procedures §3.2.

¹⁵⁶ W3C §3.4.1: the Team Contact is the interface to the rest of the organization. Referral of media inquiries to the AII Liaison is that function. Personal-capacity speech with a clear disclaimer is proposal-specific.

6.1. New members shall be provided with: (a) the Working Group Charter and these Operating Procedures; (b) the Working Group's current Work Plan and the minutes of the three most recent meetings; (c) a brief orientation from the Chair or Vice Chair covering the Working Group's current stage of work.¹⁵⁷

6.2. New members are encouraged to observe one meeting before taking on active assignments, though this is not required.¹⁵⁸

7. Member Participation and Inactivity

7.1. Active membership as defined in Article III.3 of the Charter requires attendance at one meeting and contribution to one deliverable activity per six-month period. The Chair shall track participation and notify members approaching inactive status with at least thirty days' advance notice.¹⁵⁹

7.2. A member who has become inactive may be reinstated to active status by attending one meeting and notifying the Chair of their intention to resume active participation.¹⁶⁰

7.3. If an officer becomes inactive for sixty or more consecutive days without prior notice, the Vice Chair may assume the Chair's duties on an interim basis and the Working Group shall schedule an election at its next meeting.¹⁶¹

8. Review Cadence for These Procedures

8.1. These Operating Procedures shall be reviewed by the collective Working Groups no later than twelve months after initial adoption and annually thereafter. Proposed amendments shall be circulated to all Working Group members at least thirty days before any vote.¹⁶²

¹⁵⁷ No predecessor specifies an onboarding packet. The clause exists because open membership (Charter §3.1; ANSI ER §1.1) only works if a new member can recover the Charter, these Procedures, the current Work Plan, recent minutes, and the group's present stage.

¹⁵⁸ No predecessor requires a waiting meeting. Observation is encouraged, not required, so onboarding does not become a waiting-period barrier contrary to ANSI ER §1.1 openness.

¹⁵⁹ Implements Charter §3.3. Thirty days' notice before inactive status is proposal-specific due process. RFC 2418 has no roster and therefore no inactivity track.

¹⁶⁰ No predecessor states a reinstatement rule. Inactivity is a status, not expulsion under Charter §3.7. Attendance at one meeting plus notice to the Chair restores active status so the six-month test can restart without a new admission vote.

¹⁶¹ RFC 2418 §4 allows the Area Director to choose new Chairs if the group cannot complete its work. This Charter keeps officer selection with the group (Charter §4.1). Sixty days' officer inactivity, interim Vice Chair service, and election at the next meeting are the local continuity rule.

¹⁶² W3C §11: Process revision requires Advisory Committee review of at least 28 days. Charter §10.2: Operating Procedures are amended by two-thirds, with Liaison notification. A twelve-month first review, annual reviews thereafter, and thirty days' circulation are the local cadence. W3C Process does not require annual review of group procedures.

APPENDIX C: PREDECESSOR GOVERNANCE DOCUMENTS AND RESOURCES

The draft Charter and Operating Procedures in Appendices A and B draw on the governance frameworks of established technical coordination bodies. The following primary documents are publicly available and are commended to participants in the Charter Development Session for review prior to the November 2026 Symposium.

IEEE Technical Activities Board Operations Manual (incorporating changes approved through the February 2023 TAB meeting). TAB structures for membership, officers, meeting notice, minutes, quorum, committee-member removal, Society publication authorization, and monitoring inform Articles III–V, VII, and X. Society Technical Committees are authorized in §4.2 but are not specified in detail. Pinpoints appear in the footnotes to Appendix A. The ieeefirst.org URL below returned a non-text stub at retrieval; a June 2026 print-to-PDF lacked an extractable text layer. A readable February 2023 copy is at <https://ieeefirst.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/04/tab-operations-manual.pdf>.

Available: <https://www.ieee.org/content/dam/ieee-org/ieee/web/org/tab/tab-operations-manual.pdf>

IETF RFC 2418: IETF Working Group Guidelines and Procedures. RFC 2418 establishes the governance model for IETF Working Groups, including the "rough consensus" decision standard and milestone-based accountability. The AII Charter's consensus-seeking model in Article VI and meeting procedures in Article V draw on RFC 2418.

Available: <https://rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc2418.html>

W3C Process Document (2023). The W3C Process Document specifies the process by which W3C Working Groups develop Technical Reports. The AII Operating Procedures' deliverable development process (Section 3) and amendment cadence (Section 8) draw on W3C process structures.

Available: <https://www.w3.org/2023/Process-20231103/>

IRS Form 1023 Sample Conflict of Interest Policy (Appendix A to Form 1023; text as reproduced by FREDLA). Article IX disclosure, recusal, minute-recording, and undisclosed-conflict review follow this sample. The COBIT landing page contains no operative disclosure or recusal text and is not a source for Article IX. The official IRS form mentions Appendix A but does not reprint the policy.

Available:

https://www.fredla.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/01/sample-conflict_of_interest-policy.pdf and <https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/form-1023-purpose-of-conflict-of-interest-policy>

ANSI Essential Requirements (2010 edition via NIST; a 2025 ANSI edition exists but was not retrievable at citation). Section 1.1 (openness; no undue financial barriers; voting membership not conditional on organization membership) informs Charter §§3.2 and 9.4. Section 2.7's example consensus test—a majority of the body casting a vote and two-thirds of those voting, not counting abstentions—informs the two-thirds thresholds in Articles VI and X. ANSI ER does not contain a personal conflict-of-interest or recusal rule.

Available: <https://www.nist.gov/document/2010ansiessentialrequirementspdf>

IETF RFC 5378: Rights Contributors Provide to the IETF Trust. Article VIII tracks RFC 5378 on employer or sponsor permission (§5.1), contributor retention of underlying rights (§5.10), and exclusive official publication of the adopted text (§§3.6, 5.9). CC BY 4.0 after publication, the exclusive AII imprint, and AII-POL-IP-001 (still in development) are proposal-specific. RFC 8179 (patent disclosure) and the W3C Patent Policy are not sources for Article VIII; that article has no patent clause.

Available: <https://www.rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc5378>

IEEE-SA Standards Board Operations Manual, clause 5. The IEEE-SA ballot rule is 75 percent Approve among Approve plus Do Not Approve with comment (§5.4.3.5), not two-thirds. Articles VI and X therefore do not take their supermajority from IEEE-SA ballot math. IEEE-SA remains a source for the idea of a recorded supermajority before an official output advances, and for sponsor review of work products. Available: <https://standards.ieee.org/about/policies/opman/sect5/>

Available: <https://standards.ieee.org/about/policies/>

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